

OECD Style Guide (Fourth Edition)



OECD Style Guide (Fourth Edition)

This work is published under the responsibility of the Secretary-General of the OECD. The opinions expressed and arguments employed herein do not necessarily reflect the official views of the Member countries of the OECD.

This document, as well as any data and map included herein, are without prejudice to the status of or sovereignty over any territory, to the delimitation of international frontiers and boundaries and to the name of any territory, city or area.

Please cite this publication as:

OECD (2025), *OECD Style Guide (Fourth Edition)*, OECD Publishing, Paris, <https://doi.org/10.1787/2ca15c7e-en>.

ISBN 978-92-64-57671-1 (print)
ISBN 978-92-64-34105-0 (PDF)
ISBN 978-92-64-77146-8 (HTML)

Photo credits: Cover © OECD. Some rights reserved <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc/3.0/igo/deed.en>.

Corrigenda to OECD publications may be found at: <https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/support/corrigenda.html>.

© OECD 2025



Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)

This work is made available under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International licence. By using this work, you accept to be bound by the terms of this licence (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>).

Attribution – you must cite the work.

Translations – you must cite the original work, identify changes to the original and add the following text: *In the event of any discrepancy between the original work and the translation, only the text of the original work should be considered valid.*

Adaptations – you must cite the original work and add the following text: *This is an adaptation of an original work by the OECD. The opinions expressed and arguments employed in this adaptation should not be reported as representing the official views of the OECD or of its Member countries.*

Third-party material – the licence does not apply to third-party material in the work. If using such material, you are responsible for obtaining permission from the third party and for any claims of infringement.

You must not use the OECD logo, visual identity or cover image without express permission or suggest the OECD endorses your use of the work.

Any dispute arising under this licence shall be settled by arbitration in accordance with the Permanent Court of Arbitration (PCA) Arbitration Rules 2012. The seat of arbitration shall be Paris (France). The number of arbitrators shall be one.

Preface

As a results-driven and evidence-based organisation, clear language and persuasive communication are vital for the OECD as we advance our mission of better policies for better lives.

This fourth edition of the *OECD Style Guide* outlines the rules and conventions to be used in OECD writing. It is designed to assist authors and editors in producing high-quality, consistent content that resonates with diverse audiences across various dissemination channels.

Whether you're writing a report, blog, social media post, web content, podcast or video script, this Guide will help ensure that your work is accessible, effective and follows the OECD style.

A handwritten signature in black ink, consisting of a large, stylized 'S' followed by a horizontal line and a loop.

Stéphane Levesque

OECD Director of Communications

Acknowledgements

The *OECD Style Guide* is the work of many colleagues. This edition was launched by Janine Treves, Susana Garcia-Lorenzo, Florence Guérinot and Anne La Rivière, and continued by Kate Lancaster, Sandrine Abrazian, Florence Guérinot and Anne La Rivière. This new edition also benefitted greatly from review, comments, suggestions or other support from Robert Akam, Angela Attrey, Alizée Aubertin, Lena Bodeit, Saoirse Boret, Brunella Boselli, Jocelene Bonneau, Catherine Bremer, Tim Bulman, Christelle Casado, Jonathan Challener, Caterina Cherubini, Genieve Crump, Maria Dorriots, Larisa Drustinac, Vincent Finat-Duclos, Hanna-Mari Kilpelainen, Katherine Kraig-Ernandes, Carmen Fernandez Biezma, Karena Garnier, Damian Garnys, Meral Gedik, Delphine Grandrieux, Başak Grosmangin, Liv Gudmundson, Élise Hégédus, Lucy Hulett, Julian Knott, Juliet Lawal, Karine Lepron, Patricia Lotzer, Coline Merle, Terri Mitton, Mina Nazaretyan, Luz Otero, Lily Parker, Michèle Patterson, Marie-Noëlle Pegoraro, Anne-Lise Prigent, Valérie Pucheu, Camille Raymond, Catherine Sauvet-Tricoire, Alexa Segal, Wendy Stokle, Alexander Summerfield, Andrea Uhrhammer, Élisabeth Villoutreix and Véronique Zebdi. Many thanks to all involved for their contributions.

Table of contents

Preface	3
Acknowledgements	4
Reader's guide	9
1 Abbreviations, acronyms and signs	11
Abbreviations and acronyms	12
Commonly used abbreviations, signs and symbols	13
Key differences between English and French	15
2 Bibliographical references, citations and notes	16
Citing sources in-text	17
Citing full sources in the references section	18
Referencing legal documents and legislation	25
Sources of boxes, figures, infographics and tables	26
Notes	27
Notes in boxes, figures, infographics and tables	27
3 Capitalisation	29
Publications	30
Proper nouns and official titles	32
Compass points	33
Capitalisation for specific versus generic terms	34
Key differences between English and French	35
4 Country and territory names, codes and currencies, and territorial disclaimers	36
Country and territory names	37
Visual representations of countries and territories	38
ISO country and territory codes	38
ISO currency codes	38
Naming sensitivities	41
Territorial disclaimers and footnotes	41

Geographic and economic groupings	41
Key differences between English and French	43
5 Dates and time	44
Dates	45
Time	45
Centuries and age	45
Days of the week and months	46
Seasons	47
Time periods	47
Key differences between English and French	49
6 Hyphenation	50
Adjectives and adverbs	51
Compound proper nouns and adjectives	52
Dangling hyphens	52
Doubled hyphens	53
Non-breaking hyphens	54
Prefixes	54
Repeated letters	55
7 Inclusive language	56
Age	57
Disability	57
Gender-neutral language	58
Personal pronouns	59
Race and ethnicity	59
Sexual orientation	60
8 Italics, roman and bold type	61
Italic type	62
Roman type	63
Using italic and roman type together	63
Bold	64
Underlining	64
9 Numbers and units of measure	65
Cardinal numbers	66
Decimal fractions	67
Non-decimal fractions	67
Negative numbers	68
Ordinal numbers	68

Percentages	69
Numbers with four or more digits	70
Units of measure	70
Key differences between English and French	73
10 The OECD and other international organisations	74
Referring to the OECD	75
Referring to OECD Members, non-Members, Key Partners and accession candidate countries	75
Using OECD official titles	76
Referring to other international organisations	77
11 Punctuation	79
Ampersand	80
Apostrophe	81
Breaks and hard spaces	81
Colon	82
Comma	83
Ellipses	83
En-dash	84
Exclamation mark	85
Forward slash	85
Full stop (period)	86
Lists	87
Parentheses	88
Question mark	89
Quotation marks	89
Semi-colon	90
Square brackets	90
Key differences between English and French	91
12 Quotations	92
Long quotes	93
Short quotes	93
Quotations and punctuation	94
Key differences between English and French	95
13 Spelling and usage	96
British English spelling	97
Choosing the right words	97
Plurals	104

14 Translation and terms in other languages	105
AGORA translation portal	106
Word count coefficients for translation	106
Using titles, terms and expressions from other languages	106
Avoiding confusion between English and French terms	108
Resources	111

Reader's guide

This new edition of the *OECD Style Guide* focusses on the rules and conventions used in OECD writing. It is designed to help OECD authors and editors quickly and easily find the information they need and to support them in creating clear, consistent content.

These rules and conventions apply to **all** OECD material, regardless of format or dissemination channel. Guidance on good writing, and on OECD publishing rules and processes, are now available to OECD authors and editors via an internal platform: the “OECD Communications Guidance Portal” (<https://com-apps.oecd.org/com-guidance-portal/en>).

New features

- “Do” and “Don’t” instructions for each topic covered.
- Tables illustrating “Key differences between English and French” usage for many topics.

Revised structure

Keen users of the *OECD Style Guide: Third Edition* will note that this new edition has fewer chapters than its predecessor. Some chapters have been merged into other chapters or removed, as explained below.

<i>OECD Style Guide: Third Edition</i>	<i>OECD Style Guide (Fourth Edition)</i>
Part I: Publishing at the OECD	Now covered in documents available on the OECD Communications Guidance Portal .
Breaks and hard spaces	Moved into the Punctuation chapter.
Disclaimers	Moved into the Country and territory names, codes and currencies, and territorial disclaimers chapter.
Foreign words and expressions	Removed. Advised to avoid these in the Spelling and usage chapter and the Translation and terms in other languages chapter.
Gender-neutral language	Moved into the Inclusive language chapter.
International organisations	Expanded and moved into The OECD and other international organisations chapter.
Notes	Moved into Bibliographical references, citations and notes chapter.
Personal pronouns	Moved into the Inclusive language chapter.

Format and updates

The *OECD Style Guide* is available as a webbook and a PDF. Minor updates will be made on an ongoing basis as needed and communicated to OECD staff. If major revisions are needed, a new edition will be published.

Updated March 2026 to correct formatting and typos.

1 Abbreviations, acronyms and signs

Abbreviations and acronyms are commonly used in both formal and informal writing to increase readability and conciseness. However, improper use can lead to confusion and misinterpretation.

General rules

- An **abbreviation** is a shortened form of a word or phrase ([Prof for Professor or etc. for et cetera](#)).
- An **acronym** is a word formed from the initial letters of a phrase ([OECD, EU](#)). Acronyms can be pronounced letter by letter ([OECD](#)) or as a word ([NATO](#)).
- Lists of common abbreviations are provided below.

See also: Bibliographical references, citations and notes; Country and territory names, codes and currencies, and territorial disclaimers; Dates and time; Numbers and units of measure; The OECD and other international organisations; Translation and terms in other languages.

Abbreviations and acronyms

Do

- ✓ Always spell out the full form of a term on the first use in a document followed by the abbreviation or acronym in parentheses. Once introduced, use the abbreviation or acronym consistently throughout the text.
- ✓ Always double check that the acronym is correct, referring to that used by the source institution or entity.
- ✓ Use abbreviations and acronyms that are well known to your audience. If you have many, or if you must use lesser-known ones for technical terms, provide a list of definitions.
- ✓ Only use abbreviations or acronyms in figures, infographics and tables if space constraints are significant. Ensure that those used are explained in the surrounding text on first usage.
- ✓ Use uppercase letters without full stops for acronyms, whether they are pronounced as a word ([NATO](#)) or read letter by letter ([OECD](#)).

[The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development \(OECD\) launched the Programme for International Student Assessment \(PISA\) in 1997. More than 80 countries participated in PISA in 2023.](#)

- ✓ For acronyms originating from another language, use the widely accepted English name in full and include the original name and acronym in parentheses. If the term is used frequently in the text, consider adding a list of all acronyms and abbreviations and use the original acronym in the text.

[The National Digital Strategy Office \(*Coordinación de la Estrategia Digital Nacional*, CEDN\)](#)

- ✓ Use the “©” symbol when noting the copyright of an image or photo (© Author name/Image bank name): © J. Smith/Shutterstock.com.
- ✓ Use “the” before an acronym only if it is read letter by letter (“the UN” but “UNESCO” or “ESA” not “the ESA”).

Don't

- ✗ Overuse acronyms and abbreviations; only introduce them if a term occurs frequently.
- ✗ Invent abbreviations or use non-standard ones.
- ✗ Use full stops (periods) in common abbreviations and acronyms unless they are part of a formal name or established convention.
- ✗ Use an apostrophe when pluralising acronyms.
- ✗ Use “the” before the acronym if it is being used as an adjective (OECD experts agreed...).
 - ☹ There are many IO's in the UN system (W.H.O.).
 - 😊 There are many IOs in the UN system (the WHO).
- ✗ Abbreviate months or days of the week in full text, titles or subtitles; only abbreviate in figures, infographics or tables if space is limited.

Commonly used abbreviations, signs and symbols

Academic writing

cf.	compare or refer to
e.g.	for example
ed., eds.	editor, editors
etc.	<i>et cetera</i>
et al.	and others
i.e.	that is to say
max.	maximum
min.	minimum
NB	<i>nota bene</i>
ibid.	<i>Ibidem</i>
n.d.	no date
No.	number
op.	opus
op. cit.	<i>opus citatum</i>
p.	page
pp.	pages
P.S.	post scriptum (appears before text added below the signature of a letter)

Q	quarter (unit of time equal to three months)
Vol.	volume
vs.	versus

Contracted titles

Dr, Drs	Doctor, Doctors
Prof	Professor
Mr, Ms, Mx	Honorifics to be placed before the last name: Mr for men, Ms for women, Mx for those who do not wish to use a gender-specific honorific

See also: Full stop (period).

Statistics

..	missing value
n.a.	not available
x	not applicable
0	nil or negligible
 	break in series
c	confidential data
e	estimated value
f	forecast value
p	provisional data

Symbols and mathematical signs

~	approximately
*	asterisk
@	“at” sign
÷	division
=	equal
>	greater than
#	hashtag
<	less than
+	plus
-	minus
x	multiplication

Note: Always place a non-breaking space before and after the symbols and signs in this table, except for “at” signs, asterisks and hashtags.

Key differences between English and French

English	French
The full form of an acronym in English always uses title case. The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD)	The full form of an acronym in French always uses sentence case. <i>Organisation de coopération et de développement économiques (OCDE)</i>
A lowercase “s” can be added to an acronym in English when it refers to a plural term. About 70% of international trade involves global value chains (GVCs) .	Acronyms never take an “s” in French; they are invariable. <i>Environ 70 % des échanges internationaux mobilisent des chaînes de valeur mondiales (CVM).</i>
The “N” in “number” is in upper case while the “o” is in lower case and followed by a full stop (No. 59).	The “n” in “numéro” is in lower case and the “o” in “numéro” is styled in superscript (<i>n^o 59</i>).
The abbreviation for “volume” is written with an upper case “V” (Vol. 6).	The abbreviation for “volume” is written with a lower case “v” (<i>vol. 6</i>).
The abbreviation for “edition” can be singular or plural (<i>ed. or eds.</i>).	The abbreviation for “edition” must include the accent on the “e” (<i>éd.</i>).

2 Bibliographical references, citations and notes

Bibliographical references and citations provide the necessary information for readers to locate and verify the sources used in the document. Proper acknowledgement of source materials ensures the credibility, transparency and accessibility of OECD content.

General rules

- All OECD authors are required to provide the sources for concepts, data and quotations used in their publications.
- The OECD provides a citation tool, Mendeley, available through O.N.E Author.
- Citing your sources as you draft saves time.

See also: Capitalisation; Italics, roman and bold type; Punctuation.

Citing sources in-text

- All source material, whether printed or digital, whether a publication or a media or multimedia product, can be cited in-text, following the rules below.
- By providing key information in parentheses, in-text citations provide immediate reference to sources without interrupting the flow of reading.

Do

- ✓ Use the author-date system for in-text citations.
 - For one author, include the author's surname and the year of publication, as well as page number(s) if desired.
 - For up to three authors, list all; for four or more authors, use the first author's surname and "et al."
 - When several works are cited in the same place, cite them within parentheses, separated by semi-colons.
 - The author(s) may also be cited by name followed by the publication date in parentheses.
 - For forthcoming works, list the author's surname and "forthcoming".
 - For unpublished works, list the author's surname and "unpublished".
 - For works without a publication date, list the author's surname and "n.d."
- ✓ See the table "In-text citations" for examples.
- ✓ Ensure that for each source you cite in-text, the full citation appears in your reference list.

Don't

- ✗ Include excessive in-text citations in a single sentence, integrate them meaningfully.
- ✗ Make generic statements without proper sourcing.
- ✗ Place source citations in footnotes or endnotes.

In-text citations

Type	Citation
Single author	Strengthening a “culture of professionalism”, in which staff are proud to belong to the entity, accompanied by “soft” incentives, could compensate for wage gaps with the private sector (OECD, 2016 _[1]).
Multiple authors	Co-ordinated industry-wide collaboration is essential to ensuring that decarbonisation efforts are effective, economically viable and resilient (Deng and Mi, 2023 _[5]). Capital flows into emerging-market economies have picked up this year, supported by solid growth, the improving inflation outlook and enhanced fiscal and monetary policy frameworks (Hardy et al., 2024 _[2]).
Multiple works	These areas have been examined in a series of OECD/EUIPO reports in recent years (OECD/EUIPO, 2018 _[10] ; OECD/EUIPO, 2020 _[11] ; OECD/EUIPO, 2021 _[12]).
Author names in text	Deng and Mi (2023 _[5]) note that without co-ordinated industry-wide collaboration decarbonisation efforts will not be effective, economically viable and resilient.
No publication date	Several case studies suggest (OECD, n.d. _[23]) that effective policy solutions exist.
Forthcoming	Depending on the initiative, the consultation plan may include a call for evidence, planned public consultation, targeted consultation, working groups and so on (OECD, forthcoming _[24]).
Unpublished	The data show significant disparities between the two regions (Smith, unpublished _[7]).

Citing full sources in the references section

- Include all sources cited in the text in your references section.
- All media and multimedia sources, regardless of content type or format, must be cited in-text and in the appropriate reference section.

Do

- ✓ Style the author names as follows:
 - For a single author, use “last name, first initial”: Smith, J.
 - For two authors, use “last name, first initial and first initial last name”: Smith, J. and M. N’diaye
 - For three authors, list all, using “last name, first initial” then “first initial last name”: Smith, J., M. N’diaye and A. Singh
 - For four or more authors, use “et al.”: Smith, J. et al.
 - For editor(s) use “last name, first initial (ed.)/(eds.)”: Rossi, P. (ed.) or Ito, F. and H. Aalto (eds.)

- ✓ Style institutional author names as follows:
 - For a single institution, use the institution's acronym (or full name if they do not have an acronym): [OECD](#)
 - For two or three institutions, use their acronyms (or full name if they do not have an acronym) separated by a slash: [OECD/World Bank/IADB](#)
 - For four or more institutions, use the acronym or full name of the first institution and "et al.": [OECD et al.](#)
- ✓ Ensure that each entry contains all relevant information as outlined in the tables and examples below.

Don't

- ✗ Include materials not referenced in your text in the references section.
- ✗ Put hyperlinks behind a title; instead, include the URL at the end when appropriate.

Citing reports

Type	Citation
Stand-alone monograph	Author(s) (Year), Report title: Report subtitle, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2025), <i>Does Healthcare Deliver?: Results from the Patient-Reported Indicator Surveys (PaRIS)</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/c8af05a5-en.
Periodicals (<i>OECD Outlooks</i> , <i>At a Glance</i> , <i>Surveys</i> , etc.)	Author(s) (Year), Report title: Report subtitle, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2024), <i>OECD Employment Outlook 2024: The Net-Zero Transition and the Labour Market</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/ac8b3538-en. • OECD (2024), <i>OECD Regions and Cities at a Glance 2024</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/f42db3bf-en. • OECD/FAO (2024), <i>OECD-FAO Agricultural Outlook 2024-2033</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris/FAO, Rome, https://doi.org/10.1787/4c5d2cfb-en. • OECD (2025), <i>OECD Economic Surveys: Luxembourg 2025</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/803b3ea1-en.

Type	Citation
Report series	Author(s) (Year), <i>Report title: Report subtitle</i>, Series Title, No. Series Report Number, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2025), <i>OECD Reviews of Labour Market and Social Policies: Bulgaria 2025</i>, OECD Reviews of Labour Market and Social Policies, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/81e7cac7-en. • OECD/SWAC (2025), <i>Roads and Conflicts in North and West Africa</i>, West African Studies, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/77474489-en. • OECD/ILO/CAWTAR (2020), <i>Changing Laws and Breaking Barriers for Women's Economic Empowerment in Egypt, Jordan, Morocco and Tunisia</i>, Competitiveness and Private Sector Development, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/ac780735-en.
Technical report	Author(s) (Year), <i>Report title: Report subtitle</i>, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2024), <i>Tax and Development at the OECD: A Retrospective (2009-2024)</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/9db734bc-en.

Citing papers and articles

Type	Citation
Policy paper, working paper	Author(s) (Year), “Paper title: Paper subtitle”, <i>Paper Series Title</i>, No. Paper number [or Volume/Issue], Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2024), “Competition in the food supply chain”, <i>OECD Roundtables on Competition Policy Papers</i>, No. 319, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/37d6b801-en. • OECD (2021), “G20 Rome guidelines for the future of tourism: OECD Report to G20 Tourism Working Group”, <i>OECD Tourism Papers</i>, No. 2021/03, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/d11080db-en. • Slawomirski, L. et al. (2025), “The economics of diagnostic safety”, <i>OECD Health Working Papers</i>, No. 176, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/fc61057a-en. Author(s) (Year), “Paper title: Paper subtitle”, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2024), “The benefits of learning the difference between facts and faith: An impact assessment”, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/16e43df1-en.

Type	Citation
Journal article	Author(s) (Year), “Article title: Article subtitle”, <i>Journal Title: Journal Subtitle</i>, Vol. Volume/Issue, page number(s), Unique URL for identifier. • Ghosh, A. (2023), “Can India Become a Green Superpower?: The Stakes of the World’s Most Important Energy Transition”, <i>Foreign Affairs</i>, Vol. 102/4, https://www.foreignaffairs.com/india/can-india-become-green-superpower. • Bulliard, J. et al. (2021), “Breast cancer screening and overdiagnosis”, <i>International Journal of Cancer</i>, Vol. 149/4, pp. 846-853, https://doi.org/10.1002/ijc.33602.

Citing short content

Type	Citation
Policy brief	Author(s) (Year), “Policy brief title: Policy brief subtitle”, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2023), “The rise and fall of public social spending with the COVID-19 pandemic”, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/12563432-en. Author(s) (Year), “Policy brief title: Policy brief subtitle”, <i>Policy Brief Series Title</i>, No. Paper number [or No. Volume/Issue, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2024), “How do governments direct support for innovation?: Lessons from recent OECD measurement and impact analysis (MABIS) work”, <i>OECD Policy Briefs</i>, No. 4, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/c1d93d1c-en.
Country note	Author(s) (Year), “Country note title: Country note subtitle”, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). • OECD (2025), “Survey of Adults Skills 2023: Germany”, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/survey-of-adults-skills-2023-country-notes_ab4f6b8c-en/germany_5f81cb66-en (accessed on 21 July 2025).
Case study	Author(s) (Year), “Case study title: Case study subtitle”, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). • OECD (2025), “Canada’s Gender-Based Analysis Plus”, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/well-being-knowledge-exchange-platform-kep_93d45d63-en/canada-s-gender-based-analysis-plus_c0ddec0a-en.html (accessed on 23 July 2025).

Citing components

Type	Citation
Chapter, annex	Author(s) (Year), “Chapter/annex title”, in <i>Report Title: Report Subtitle</i>, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2024), “SDG. Equity in the Education Sustainable Development Goal”, in <i>Education at a Glance 2024: OECD Indicators</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2024_c00cad36-en/full-report/equity-in-the-education-sustainable-development-goal_9d94cd1e.html#chapter-d1e985-23abbc641d. • OECD (2025), “Highlights from the 2025 Development Co-operation Peer Review of Luxembourg (infographic)”, in <i>OECD Development Co-operation Peer Reviews: Luxembourg 2025</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-development-co-operation-peer-reviews-luxembourg-2025_3713cf73-en/full-report/highlights-from-the-2025-development-co-operation-peer-review-of-luxembourg-infographic_8c613d69.html#introduction-d5e556. • OECD (2025), “Annex A. Statistical annex”, in <i>OECD Employment Outlook 2025: Can We Get Through the Demographic Crunch?</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-employment-outlook-2025_194a947b-en/full-report/component-10.html#annex-d1e35008-615037b21f.

Type	Citation
Box, figure, infographic and table	Author(s) (Year), “Box/Figure/Infographic/Table title”, in <i>Report Title: Report Subtitle</i>, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. • OECD (2025), “Box 4.1. At the regional level: The ecological and solidarity-based participatory budget of the Île-de-France region (France)”, in <i>Open Government for the Green Transition</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/open-government-for-the-green-transition_bfa02935-en/full-report/la-participation-au-dela-de-la-consultation-peut-garantir-un-engagement-actif-des-citoyens-dans-l-agenda-vert_07283b25.html. • OECD (2025), “Figure 1.5. Performance assessment of Ukraine’s specialised anti-corruption bodies”, in <i>OECD Integrity and Anti-Corruption Review of Ukraine</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-integrity-and-anti-corruption-review-of-ukraine_7dbe965b-en/full-report/strengthening-the-anti-corruption-and-public-integrity-framework-in-ukraine_8e7ced57.html#title-27ca0f1c05. • OECD (2022), “Infographic 1.2. Conflict and fragility”, in <i>States of Fragility 2022</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/states-of-fragility-2022_c7fedf5e-en/full-report/component-7.html#title-e9cf764634. • OECD (2025), “Table 3.1. Income tax plus employee and employer contributions less cash benefits, 2024”, in <i>Taxing Wages 2025: Decomposition of Personal Income Taxes and the Role of Tax Reliefs</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/taxing-wages-2025_b3a95829-en/full-report/effective-tax-rates-on-labour-income-in-2024_878e20ff.html#title-e2496a0277.

Citing data (including for “OECD Data Explorer”)

Type	Citation
Indicator	Author (year or n.d.), <i>Indicator Title: Indicator Subtitle</i> (indicator), Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). • OECD (2025), <i>Hours worked</i> (indicator), https://data-explorer.oecd.org/s/2db (accessed on 7 July 2025).
Dataset	Author (Year or n.d.), <i>Dataset Title: Dataset Subtitle</i> (dataset), Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). • OECD (2025), <i>Main Science and Technology Indicators</i> (dataset), https://data-explorer.oecd.org/s/2dc (accessed on 7 July 2025). • Eurostat (2023), <i>Population on 1st January by Age, Sex and Type of Projection</i> (dataset), https://doi.org/10.2908/PROJ_23NP (accessed on 7 July 2025).

Type	Citation
Dataset group	Author (Year or n.d.), <i>Datasets Group Title</i> (dataset group), Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). OECD (2025), <i>Fisheries and Aquaculture</i> (dataset group), https://data-explorer.oecd.org/s/2dd (accessed on 7 July 2025).

Note: For citations from “OECD Data Explorer”, please use its short link generator to create your URL by clicking “Share”.

Citing media and multimedia

Type	Citation
Newspaper article	Author(s) (Year), “Article title”, <i>Newspaper Title</i>, Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). Yanatma, S. (2025), “Which countries in Europe have the highest pay?”, <i>euronews</i>, https://www.euronews.com/business/2025/05/06/average-salaries-across-europe-which-countries-have-the-highest-pay (accessed on 6 May 2025).
Web page	Author(s) (Year), “Title of page/site”, Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). OECD (2025), “Environment”, https://www.oecd.org/en/topics/environment.html (accessed on 7 May 2025).
Social media post	Author name or handle (Year), Text of post, <i>Social Media Platform Title</i>, Day Month published, Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). @OECD_Social (2025), Are #training programmes equipping workers with the AI #skills they’ll need for the future? Find out with new OECD analysis http://oe.cd/bridging-ai-skills-gap #OECDAI, X, 24 April, https://x.com/OECD_Social/status/1915359904862216542 (accessed on 4 May 2025).
Blog	Author(s) (Year), “Title of page/site”, <i>Blog Title</i>, Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). Hanagata, M. (2025), “Cities leading the way in the quest for better buildings”, <i>Cogito</i>, https://oecdcoqito.blog/ (accessed on 2 May 2025).
Podcast	Author (Year), “Podcast title: Podcast subtitle”, <i>Podcast Series Title: Podcast Series Subtitle</i>, Duration: duration value, Publisher, City, Unique URL for identifier. OECD (2022), “Transition Finance: What is it and why is it needed?”, <i>OECD Podcasts</i>, Duration: 21:08, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/93a3fcb-b-en.
Video	Username (Year), “Title” [video], Day Month posted, Unique URL for identifier (accessed on Day Month Year). OECD (2024), “OECD Data, Analysis, Knowledge: Free to access. Yours to share” [video], 4 July, https://youtu.be/vL_INpY-tEE?si=Qqb7JJBam2hCE-w (accessed on 7 May 2025).

Citing forthcoming, unpublished work, work without a publication date, or deceased authors

Type	Citation
Forthcoming work	Use the correct citation style for the content type, replacing (Year) with (forthcoming); do not include a URL. • OECD (forthcoming), <i>Energy Prices and Subsidies in the Western Balkans</i>, OECD Publishing, Paris. • Beverelli, C. et al. (forthcoming), “Services trade and environmental sustainability: Conceptual linkages and empirical patterns”, OECD Publishing, Paris.
Unpublished work	Author(s) (unpublished), “Title: Subtitle”. Do not include a URL. • Smith, J. (unpublished), “Regional Growth Patterns in Europe: A New Analysis”.
Work without a publication date	Author(s) (n.d.), “Title: Subtitle”. Do not include a URL. • Doe, J. (n.d.), “Assessing trade flows: A new methodology”.
Work published after the death of its author(s)	A “death dagger”, represented by “†”, may be added after the author’s name. • Dupont, F.† (2024), <i>Monetary Policy and Economic Stability in the 20th Century</i>, Nemo Press, Paris.

Referencing legal documents and legislation

- Legal references should generally include the key relevant information, such as the issuing body, document title, and date, as well as URL if available and date accessed if appropriate.
- When citing legal documentation, domestic citation standards should be followed (e.g. the case law of the French *Conseil d’État* should be cited in the same way that the *Conseil d’État* cites its own jurisprudence).
- Many OECD Member countries maintain style guides for their national printing offices as well as databases of legislation, which may be consulted online.
- When citing legal documentation of other international organisations, the standards developed by those organisations should be followed (e.g. Directives of the European Parliament and of the Council should be cited according to EU practice).
- When referencing OECD legal instruments adopted by the OECD Council or within the framework of the OECD, the style will differ depending on whether the legal instrument is mentioned in the body of a text or included in the bibliography. Follow the examples in “Referencing OECD legal instruments”.

Referencing OECD legal instruments

Legal instrument	When mentioned by name in the text	Citing in a bibliography
Recommendation	OECD Recommendation on Responsible Innovation in Neurotechnology [OECD/LEGAL/0457]	OECD (n.d.), <i>Recommendation of the Council on Responsible Innovation in Neurotechnology</i> , OECD/LEGAL/0457, https://legalinstruments.oecd.org/en/instruments/OECD-LEGAL-0457 (accessed on 11 June 2025).
Decision	OECD Decision revising the OECD Scheme for the Application of International Standards for Fruit and Vegetables [OECD/LEGAL/0346]	OECD (n.d.), <i>Decision of the Council revising the OECD Scheme for the Application of International Standards for Fruit and Vegetables</i> , OECD/LEGAL/0346, https://legalinstruments.oecd.org/en/instruments/OECD-LEGAL-0346 (accessed on 11 June 2025).
Substantive outcome document (e.g. Declaration, Ministerial Council Statements)	OECD Declaration on Public Sector Innovation [OECD/LEGAL/0450]	OECD (n.d.), <i>Declaration on Public Sector Innovation</i> , OECD/LEGAL/0450, https://legalinstruments.oecd.org/en/instruments/OECD-LEGAL-0450 (accessed on 11 June 2025).
International agreement	Convention on Combating Bribery of Foreign Public Officials in International Business Transactions [OECD/LEGAL/0293]	OECD (n.d.), <i>Convention on Combating Bribery of Foreign Public Officials in International Business Transactions</i> , OECD/LEGAL/0293, https://legalinstruments.oecd.org/en/instruments/OECD-LEGAL-0293 (accessed on 11 June 2025).

Note: In your text, take care to make clear to readers whether you are citing a revision of the instrument or its original date of entry into force and use the appropriate year in your citation.

Sources of boxes, figures, infographics and tables

- Every box, figure, infographic and table must clearly cite its source or sources. Use the **short reference** system: **Author(s) (Year), Title, Unique URL for identifier** (if possible).
Source: CERED/HCP (2024), *Population Census*, https://www.hcp.ma/Recensement-population-RGPH-2014_a2941.html.
- These sources must be included below the box, figure, infographic and table, and also in the appropriate reference section.
- If your box, figure, infographic and table is a direct reproduction of an external source, without being adapted or modified, you must ensure you have the right to reproduce it. Simply citing the source is not sufficient.

- If you adapt a box, figure, infographic and table from another source, make this clear in your citation.

Source: Based on OECD (2022), *Global Plastics Outlook*, Figure 2.2, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/2022/02/global-plastics-outlook_a653d1c9/full-report/component-7.html#figure-d1e2639.

- If the source is OECD work that is not accessible to the general public and is published for the first time in the work at hand, the publication and its material are the source. For boxes, there is no need to list the publication itself. For data, list the source of the data, even if not public (“Survey of.../Country consultation...”). Do not use “Source: OECD” or “Source: Authors”.

Notes

- Notes provide additional information or commentary without interrupting the flow of the main text.
- Notes are not used to provide sources.

Do

- ✓ Use endnotes, not footnotes.
- ✓ Use superscript 1, 2, 3... as note symbols.
- ✓ Number endnotes consecutively by chapter (for reports) or throughout the text (papers, short content), using the automatic notes function in O.N.E Author.
- ✓ Place endnote symbols after punctuation, either at the end of the sentence or within it if the note only refers to part of the sentence.

The countries benefitted from higher contributions than pensions benefits and other expenditure.¹

The productivity disparities may stem from differences in cross-border trade dynamics² and the availability of investment.

Don't

- ✗ Use footnotes, as they disrupt the formatting of your manuscript in production.
- ✗ Place a note on a title or on a section heading.
- ✗ Insert boxes, figures, infographics or tables into a note.
- ✗ Insert a note into another note.

Notes in boxes, figures, infographics and tables

- Notes in boxes, figures, infographics and tables are numbered separately from the main body text.

Do

- ✓ Insert note symbols manually as superscripted numerals in boxes, figures, infographics and tables.
- ✓ Use superscript **1, 2, 3**... as note symbols.

Don't

- ✗ Place a note on the title.
- ✗ Use notes to provide the source(s) for boxes, figures, infographics and tables.
- ✗ Insert a note into a source, another note or an endnote.

3 Capitalisation

Using capitalisation correctly is important for clarity and consistency, while excessive capitalisation distracts from readability. Correct usage allows the reader to distinguish between proper nouns and other words and to identify visually different content types as well as levels of hierarchy in text.

General rules

- Capitalise the first letter of a word that begins a sentence and all proper nouns (names of events, persons, places, organisations, nationalities and languages).
- For titles and subtitles of books, periodicals and series, use title case.
- For all other titles and subtitles, use sentence case. If a title includes a colon, capitalise the first word following the colon.
- In most cases, specific terms may be capitalised; general terms should never be capitalised.

See also: Abbreviations, acronyms and signs; Country and territory names, codes and currencies, and territorial disclaimers.

OECD Members and Partners

- Capitalise **Member** in “OECD Member”, “OECD Members”, “OECD Member country” and “OECD Member countries”, as well as in “non-Member”.
- Capitalise both words in **Key Partners** (Brazil, China, India, Indonesia and South Africa).
- Do not capitalise **accession** or **accession candidate country**.
- Capitalise **Associate**, **Participant** and **Invitee** if the terms are being used in the context of non-Member participation in the work of in OECD subsidiary bodies in line with the general principals set out in Revised Resolution of the Council on Partnerships in OECD Bodies [\[C\(2012\)100/REV2/FINAL\]](#).
- Do not capitalise these terms when they are used as common nouns.
- Do not capitalise the term **observer**.

See also: The OECD and other international organisations.

Publications

- Publication titles and subtitles use either title case or sentence case, depending on the content type (reports, papers, policy briefs, country notes and case studies).
- In title case, each word is capitalised except for co-ordinating conjunctions, prepositions or articles.
- In sentence case, only the first word is capitalised, except for any proper nouns included.

Do

- ✓ Use **title case** for report titles and subtitles, the names of projects or initiatives, and country notes when referring to the name of the “parent” publication.
 - If a title includes a colon, capitalise the first word following it.
 - If a title includes a hyphenated adjectival phrase, capitalise both parts.

*The OECD has released a new report, **Evidence-Based Decision Making in Health Policy**.*
- ✓ Use **sentence case** for the titles and subtitles of report chapters, papers and short content.
- ✓ For all other titles and subtitles (including those of boxes, figures, infographics and tables) use sentence case.
- ✓ Use sentence case references to specific components of a report (e.g. chapters, annexes, boxes, figures, infographics and tables).

Don't

- ✗ Capitalise the letter after a hyphen within a single word, even in titles or subtitles.
 - ☹️ *OECD Development Co-Operation Peer Reviews*
 - 😊 *OECD Development Co-operation Peer Reviews*

Capitalising titles and subtitles

Type	Example
Report (title case)	• <i>OECD Review of the Corporate Governance of State-Owned Enterprises in Thailand</i> • <i>Empowered Citizens, Informed Consumers and Skilled Workers: Designing Education and Skills Policies for a Sustainable Future</i>
Working paper (sentence case)	• <i>AI skills and capabilities in Canada</i> • <i>Pooling our strengths: The power of stakeholder engagement in education and skills policy</i>
Policy paper (sentence case)	• <i>Transforming laws and norms to achieve universal sexual and reproductive health and rights</i> • <i>Mind shift, green lift: Six behavioural science trends for environmental policy</i>
Policy brief (sentence case)	• <i>Health care financing in times of high inflation</i> • <i>Attracting talent: The (no longer) remote option for regions and cities</i>
Case study (sentence case)	• <i>Ireland's application of the OECD's framework on masculinities</i> • <i>Partnerships in sustainable finance: Luxembourg's Green Exchange</i>
Country note (title case)	• <i>OECD Services Trade Restrictiveness Index: Czechia</i> • <i>Survey of Adults Skills 2023: Norway</i>

Type	Example
Components (sentence case)	- Chapter 3. Building a strategic vision for skills development for the green transition but A chapter discusses the green transition. - Table 1.4. Size and sectoral distribution of Thailand's central state-owned enterprise sector but The report included a table on Thai SOEs.

Other examples of capitalisation in titles

"e-words", "i-words" and "m-words"	"e-commerce", "m-government" but "E-commerce" and "M-government" when starting a sentence or in a title.
Definite articles that are not formally part of a name	<i>the New York Times</i> but <i>The Economist</i>
Names of seasons	Always lowercase, unless part of a title. <i>The winter temperatures were extreme.</i> but Stravinsky's <i>The Rite of Spring</i> was first performed in 1913.

Proper nouns and official titles

- Proper nouns include names of events, persons, places, things, nationalities, languages and the names of groups, organisations or institutions as well as official titles and roles if used to refer to a specific individual.

Do

- ✓ Capitalise official titles and roles when used as part of a proper noun or title ("Secretary-General", "Minister of Finance").
France's Minister of Finance announced the new budget to the National Assembly.
- ✓ Capitalise the names of groups, organisations and institutions if they are proper nouns or if the reference is specific ("the OECD", "the Working Party on Countering Illicit Trade").
The Secretary-General addressed the OECD Working Party on Pesticides.

Don't

- ✗ Capitalise generic references to roles, organisations, institutions, bodies or documents.
 - ☹️ Several Ministers and Deputy-Ministers participated in the Conference.
 - 😊 Several ministers and deputy-ministers participated in the conference.
 - ☹️ The Government proposed a Referendum.
 - 😊 The government proposed a referendum.

Compass points

- The cardinal directions are [North](#), [South](#), [East](#) and [West](#). The intercardinal directions are [Northeast](#), [Southeast](#), [Southwest](#) and [Northwest](#).
- Compass points may be capitalised in some circumstances, in order to clarify whether the term refers to a specific or a general direction.

Do

- ✓ Capitalise compass points as appropriate when part of a title.
- ✓ Capitalise compass points when referring to specific regions or when part of a proper noun.
- ✓ Use lowercase when referring to a compass point generically to describe direction.
[Providence, Rhode Island, is located on the East Coast.](#)
[Take the next left and head south on Route 12.](#)

Don't

- ✗ Hyphenate intercardinal directions (Northeast, Southeast, Southwest and Northwest).
 [The North-West Passage is a sea lane in the Arctic Ocean.](#)
 [The Northwest Passage is a sea lane in the Arctic Ocean.](#)
- ✗ Use the term “[Eastern European](#)” when referring to any OECD Member country. Instead use “[Central and Eastern European](#)”.

Capitalisation for specific versus generic terms

- Generally, specific terms may be capitalised while generic references never should be.

When to capitalise... or not

Examples	Specific vs. generic
Historical periods	• the Renaissance, the French Revolution, World War II but the past decade, for a century
Internet terms	• the Internet, the OECD Intranet but a web page, a website, a web manager
Acts, directives, legislation	• The 1965 Road Act but The act was passed by simple majority • The Open Government Directive establishes deadlines for action but A directive is a legislative act of the European Union • The Privatisation Bill but Congress is debating a bill
Decisions, declarations, resolutions	• The OECD Council Decision on... but Their decision was unanimous • The Ministerial Declaration on the Protection of Privacy of Global Networks but The group adopted a declaration • The Resolution of the Council on the Draft Convention on the Protection of Foreign Property was adopted in 1967 but Council will review two resolutions
Guidelines	• OECD Guidelines on the Protection of Privacy but OECD Members called for new guidelines
Ministerial meetings	• The last Ministerial Council Meeting ended in agreement but The OECD Council meets at ministerial level once a year

Key differences between English and French

English	French
Day and month	
Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, etc.	<i>lundi, mardi, mercredi, etc.</i>
January, February, March, etc.	<i>janvier, février, mars, etc.</i>
Nationality as adjective and noun	
the French language	<i>la langue française</i>
the French people	<i>les Français</i>
a French woman, a French man	<i>une française, un français</i>
Publication titles	
<i>Anti-Corruption and Integrity Outlook 2024</i> (report title)	Perspectives de l'OCDE sur la lutte contre la corruption et l'intégrité 2024
<i>How's Life? 2024: Well-being and Resilience in Times of Crisis</i> (report title and subtitle)	Comment va la vie ? 2024 : Bien-être et résilience en temps de crise
Chapter titles	
1. Fertility trends across the OECD: Underlying drivers and the role for policy	1. <i>Évolution de la fécondité dans la zone OCDE : déterminants sous-jacents et rôle de l'action publique</i>
OECD titles and terms	
Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development	<i>Organisation de coopération et de développement économiques</i>
The Permanent Representative of France to the OECD	<i>le Représentant permanent de la France auprès de l'OCDE</i>
The Council Secretariat and the Committee Secretariat	<i>le Secrétariat du Conseil et le secrétariat du comité</i>
the Secretary-General, the Deputy Secretaries-General	<i>le Secrétaire général, les Secrétaires généraux adjoints</i>
the Directorate for Financial and Enterprise Affairs	<i>la Direction des affaires financières et des entreprises</i>
the Division for Communications Impact, Standards and Capacity Building (but also Communications Impact, Standards and Capacity Building division)	<i>la Division de l'évaluation de la communication, des standards et du développement des expertises</i>
the Service for Translation (but also the Translation service)	<i>le service de traduction</i>
the Steel Committee, the Working Group on Bribery	<i>le Comité de l'acier, le Groupe de travail sur la corruption</i>
the draft Recommendation, the draft Declaration, the draft Decision	<i>le projet de recommandation, le projet de déclaration, le projet de décision</i>

4 Country and territory names, codes and currencies, and territorial disclaimers

Referring to countries and territories incorrectly or depicting them in maps inaccurately can raise diplomatic sensitivities. To avoid this, follow the guidance provided by the Directorate for Legal Affairs and the Directorate for Communications regarding country and territory names and codes, currency codes and symbols, territorial disclaimers, and maps.

Country and territory names

- The OECD has specific naming and style conventions for Members, non-Members, Key Partners and accession candidate countries.
- The Directorate for Legal Affairs (LEG) provides a list of the official country and territory long names, short names, names in lists, tables, maps and graphics, and ISO codes, to be used in OECD content:
<https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/leg/Pages/Home.aspx#Countries%2c%20Territories%20and%20Diplomatic%20Sensitivities>.
- If in doubt, or if asked to apply different naming, contact LEGILU@oecd.org for clarification.
- Use these names in all content, regardless of format and of whether it is published externally or remains internal.
- Remember that there are small differences in spelling between many names in English and French; always check the spelling is correct for the language in which you are drafting and refer to the table at the end of this chapter.

See also: Abbreviations, acronyms and signs; The OECD and other international organisations.

Do

- ✓ Only use the country and territory names and codes included in the list provided by LEG.
- ✓ Use the long name the first time a country or territory is mentioned in the text of the document, define the short name for what follows, then use the short name thereafter.
[The Republic of Türkiye \(hereafter “Türkiye”\) is a Member of the OECD. Türkiye was one of the 20 founders of the OECD in 1960.](#)
- ✓ Add “the” before these countries: the Netherlands, the Russian Federation, the Slovak Republic, the United Kingdom and the United States. These countries always take the singular verb form.
- ✓ Use “euro area” when referring to the EU Member States that use the euro.
- ✓ Spell out country and territory names in full when used as nouns ([the United States, the United Kingdom](#)) but use abbreviations when used as adjectives ([US companies, UAE delegates, UK unions](#)).
- ✓ Always list countries and territories alphabetically (in English) in text unless the list provided by LEG indicates otherwise. Always check this list for any exceptions or changes; for example, the People’s Republic of China is listed under “C” ([China, the People’s Republic of](#)). If no letter is specified, the entry is under the first letter of the country or territory’s name ([“R” for the Russian Federation](#)).
- ✓ Countries and territories may be listed non-alphabetically if there is a specific reason for another order, such as a ranking.
[The top three performing countries were Japan, Canada and New Zealand.](#)

Don't

- ✗ Use any names for countries or territories that differ from those in the list provided by LEG under any circumstances.

Visual representations of countries and territories

- Given the sensitive nature of any visual representation of a country or territory, such as a map, a flag, an emoji, an image, or a photo, use such representations only with moderation and caution.

Do

- ✓ Use the map model proposed by LEG <https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/leg/Pages/Home.aspx>. Follow the technical guidance and list of points to verify provided by LEG.
- ✓ If you must use a flag image, only use a flag to designate a country, never for a territory. Verify that the flag is the correct one for the country, as flags change over time.

Do not

- ✗ Import flag symbols into the back office of OECD.org (AEM). Only use the flag symbols provided by AEM itself.
- ✗ Use emojis to represent flags. See: <https://com-apps.oecd.org/com-guidance-portal/en/how-to/how-to-create-consistent-content-on-oecd-social-media-platforms>.

ISO country and territory codes

- ISO codes for countries and territories should generally be avoided, as the ISO country and territory names to which they relate do not align with OECD practice. In cases where the use of ISO codes is necessary, a table setting out the ISO codes and the country or territory names to which they relate (in line with LEG guidance) should be added in a reader's guide.
- Consult LEG's "List of names of countries and territories and related guidelines" available at <https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/leg/Pages/Home.aspx>.

ISO currency codes

- Currencies can be designated by terms, codes or symbols.
- To avoid confusion, use the ISO code for specific currencies and the term for generic references.

The budget is **USD 5 million** but the budget is **millions** of dollars.

Do

- ✓ Use the currency code in publications, short content and web copy. Use the currency symbol if necessary due to space constraints in social media or in figures and tables.
- ✓ Place the code before the amount (USD 1 000), separated by a hard space; place symbol before the amount without a space (\$1 000). Place the term after the amount (1 000 dollars), separated by a hard space.
- ✓ Define uncommon currency codes on first use in the text.
In order to finance the merger, the company raised KGS 5 million (Kyrgyz Republic soms).
- ✓ For uncommon currencies, indicate the equivalent in a more common currency (EUR, USD).
The bank allocated IQD 1 billion (USD 750 million) to the project.
- ✓ For web and social media content, currency symbols can be used, but replace with currency codes if there is a risk of confusion.
 ☹️ Australia contributed \$100 million in aid, the United States contributed \$100 million.
 😊 Australia contributed AUD 100 million in aid, the United States contributed USD 100 million.
- ✓ Refer to the tables below for the currency names, codes and symbols for OECD Members and the euro area.

Don't

- ✗ Mix currency terms, codes and symbols. Be consistent.
 ☹️ Australia contributed AU\$ 100 million in aid, the United States contributed 100 million US Dollars and the European Union 100 million EUR.
 😊 Australia contributed AUD 100 million in aid, the United States contributed USD 100 million, and the European Union contributed EUR 100 million.

Currencies and their ISO codes for OECD Member countries and the euro area

Member country	Singular	Plural	Code	Symbol
Australia	Australian dollar	Australian dollars	AUD	\$
Austria	euro	euros	EUR	€
Belgium	euro	euros	EUR	€
Canada	Canadian dollar	Canadian dollars	CAD	\$
Chile	Chilean peso	Chilean pesos	CLP	\$
Colombia	Colombian peso	Colombian pesos	COP	\$
Costa Rica	Costa Rican colon	Costa Rican colones	CRC	₡
Czechia	koruna	koruny	CZK	Kč
Denmark	Danish krone	Danish kroner	DKK	Kr.
Estonia	euro	euros	EUR	€
Finland	euro	euros	EUR	€
France	euro	euros	EUR	€
Germany	euro	euros	EUR	€
Greece	euro	euros	EUR	€
Hungary	forint	forints	HUF	Ft
Iceland	Iceland krona	Iceland kronur	ISK	Kr
Ireland	euro	euros	EUR	€
Israel	new Israeli shekel	new Israeli shekels	ILS	₪
Italy	euro	euros	EUR	€
Japan	yen	yen	JPY	¥
Korea	won	won	KRW	₩
Latvia	euro	euros	EUR	€
Lithuania	euro	euros	EUR	€
Luxembourg	euro	euros	EUR	€
Mexico	Mexican peso	Mexican pesos	MXN	\$
Netherlands	euro	euros	EUR	€
New Zealand	New Zealand dollar	New Zealand dollars	NZD	\$
Norway	Norwegian krone	Norwegian kroner	NOK	Kr
Poland	zloty	zlotys	PLN	zł
Portugal	euro	euros	EUR	€
Slovak Republic	euro	euros	EUR	€
Slovenia	euro	euros	EUR	€
Spain	euro	euros	EUR	€
Sweden	Swedish krona	Swedish kronor	SEK	Kr
Switzerland	Swiss franc	Swiss francs	CHF	Fr.

Member country	Singular	Plural	Code	Symbol
Türkiye	Turkish lira	Turkish liras	TRY	₺
United Kingdom	pound sterling	pounds sterling	GBP	£
United States	US dollar	US dollars	USD	\$
Euro area	euro	euros	EUR	€

Currencies and their ISO codes for Key Partners

Key Partner	Singular	Plural	Code	Symbol
Brazil	Brazilian real	Brazilian reals	BRL	R\$
China (People's Republic of)	Yuan renminbi	Yuan renminbi	CNY	¥
India	Indian rupee	Indian rupees	INR	₹
Indonesia	rupiah	rupiahs	IDR	Rp
South Africa	rand	rand	ZAR	R

Naming sensitivities

- Always consult LEG's "List of names of countries and territories" (available at <https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/leg/Pages/Home.aspx>) for the latest guidance on references to certain countries and territories (e.g. Chinese Taipei, Cyprus, India, the Islamic Republic of Iran), in texts, lists, figures, tables and maps.
- If in doubt, or if asked to apply different naming, contact LEG at LEGILU@oecd.org and the Global Relations and Co-operation Directorate at GRCDIRPARTNERSHIPS@oecd.org, for clarification.

Territorial disclaimers and footnotes

- All OECD content containing statistical data on Israel that has been provided by the Israeli authorities, mentioning Kosovo or referring to the Republic of Cyprus **must** include specific territorial disclaimers or footnotes, available at: <https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/leg/Pages/Home.aspx>.

Geographic and economic groupings

- Geographic and economic grouping terms, abbreviations and acronyms are regularly used in OECD work, facilitating reading by shortening the text.
- Brevity should not come at the expense of clarity. Use geographic groupings sparingly.

Do

- ✓ Spell out on first use, followed by the acronym or abbreviation in parentheses, then use the acronym subsequently. Note that in alphabetical listings, the grouping should be classed based on the first letter of its full name.
- ✓ Refer to the table below for correct acronyms, abbreviations and names.

Abbreviation or acronyms and full names for geographic and economic groupings

Abbreviation or acronym	Full name
APEC	Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation
ASEAN	Association of Southeast Asian Nations
BRIC	Brazil, Russian Federation, India, China
BRICS	Brazil, Russian Federation, India, China, South Africa
BRIICS	Brazil, Russian Federation, India, Indonesia, China, South Africa
CEEC	Central and Eastern European Countries
CIS	Commonwealth of Independent States
EA17	Euro area countries that are also OECD Members
ECOWAS	Economic Community of West African States
EECCA	Eastern Europe, Caucasus and Central Asia
EU	European Union
EU22	OECD European Union countries
FSU	Former Soviet Union
G7, G8, G20	Group of Seven , Group of Eight , Group of Twenty
G77	The Group of 77
LAC	Latin America and the Caribbean
MENA	Middle East and North Africa
MERCOSUR	Southern Common Market
NAFTA	North American Free Trade Agreement
OACPS	Organisation of African, Caribbean and Pacific States
OECD, OECD area	Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, area encompassing OECD Member countries
OPEC	Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries
SEA	Southeast Asia
SEE	Southeast Europe

Key differences between English and French

English	French
“a” vs. “e” endings	
<i>Australia, Colombia, Estonia</i>	<i>Australie, Colombie, Estonie</i>
No hyphenation vs. hyphenation of two-word names	
<i>New Zealand, United Kingdom, United States</i>	<i>Nouvelle-Zélande, Royaume-Uni, États-Unis</i>
Other minor differences in OECD Member names	
<i>Denmark, Israel, Japan, Korea</i>	<i>Danemark, Israël, Japon, Corée</i>
Minor differences in non-Member names	
<i>Bahrain, Bhutan, Kyrgyzstan, Palau, etc.</i>	<i>Bahreïn, Bhoutan, Kirghizistan, Palaos, etc.</i>
ISO currency code placement	
The ISO currency code appears before the number (EUR 150, USD 235, CZK 1 700, etc.)	The ISO code appears after the number (150 EUR, 235 USD, 1 700 CZK, etc.)

5

Dates and time

With membership and engagement around the world, it is important to refer to dates, time and seasons in a simple and consistent way, in order to prevent ambiguity and inaccuracy.

Dates

Do

- ✓ For dates in technical documents and datasets, use the **DD-MM-YYYY** format.
- ✓ For dates in general text, use the day-month-year format. Employ numerals for the day and year and the word for the month, and do not use commas. Use hard spaces between the day and month (**15 April 1998**).

See also: Abbreviations for days; Abbreviations for months.

Don't

- ✗ Use ordinal numbers in dates.
 - ☹️ **The event is scheduled for November 15th, 2024, at 2:30 PM Paris time.**
 - 😊 **The event is scheduled for 15 November 2024 at 14:30 (UTC+1).**

Time

Do

- ✓ For time, use the 24-hour clock.
- ✓ Specify time zones if relevant. Refer to <https://www.timeanddate.com/worldclock/converter.html> for time zone names and abbreviations.

Don't

- ✗ Use AM and PM.
 - ☹️ **The first session will begin at 10:00 AM, the second at 1:00 PM.**
 - 😊 **The first session will begin at 10:00, the second at 13:00.**

Centuries and age

- Using numbers (rather than words) and correct hyphenation and capitalisation ensures that century and age are accurately expressed.

Do

- ✓ Use ordinal numbers for centuries and cardinal numbers for people's ages.
 - She turned 40 this year; the 18th century.**

Don't

- ✗ Use superscript for “th” when abbreviating ordinal numbers to refer to a century.
- ✗ Capitalise “century” unless in a title or as the first word in a sentence.
- ✗ Hyphenate the time period in age if it is a predicate adjective.

☹️ The OECD was founded in the 20th Century.

😊 The OECD was founded in the 20th century.

☹️ The president is 55 years-old.

😊 The president is 55 years old.

See *also*: Hyphenation.

Days of the week and months**Do**

- ✓ Always spell out the name of days of the week and of months in full in texts, titles and subtitles.
- ✓ If space is limited in a table, figure or graphic, or in social media text, use the abbreviations below.

See *also*: Abbreviations, acronyms and signs.

Abbreviations for days

Mon.	Monday
Tues.	Tuesday
Weds.	Wednesday
Thurs.	Thursday
Fri.	Friday
Sat.	Saturday
Sun.	Sunday

Abbreviations for months

Jan.	January
Feb.	February
Mar.	March
Apr.	April
May	May (no abbreviation)
June	June (no abbreviation)
July	July (no abbreviation)
Aug.	August
Sept.	September
Oct.	October
Nov.	November
Dec.	December

Seasons

- Seasons are opposite in the southern and northern hemispheres, leading to ambiguity if they are used to refer to time periods.

Do

- ✓ Refer to months, quarters or years to indicate time periods rather than to winter, spring, summer or autumn.

☹️ The conference was held in spring 2018.

😊 The conference was held in May 2018.

- ✓ Refer to seasons if needed for discussions of events in specific locations or weather. Be specific so that location is clear.

☹️ The river is more prone to flooding in winter than summer.

😊 The Seine is more prone to flooding in winter than summer.

Time periods

- Simple, consistent formatting of time ranges ensures your meaning is clear. Correct capitalisation of time periods allows your readers to distinguish between specific and general terms.

See also: Capitalisation.

Do

- ✓ Use all four digits of the starting year followed by an “s” (no apostrophe) to indicate a decade.

The 1990s were a decade of rapid technological change.

- ✓ To express a date range, use all four digits of the starting year followed by a hyphen and all four digits of the ending year.

Prices were stable, then rose moderately in 1998-2001.

- ✓ For time periods in publication titles, use all four digits of the starting year followed by a hyphen and all four digits of the ending year.

The OECD-FAO Agricultural Outlook 2024-2033 was launched yesterday.

- ✓ Use context to clarify the number of years covered by the date range.

The 2020-2024 average was 8 trillion bushels a day although output dropped at the end of the four-year period.

- ✓ Use a slash mark to indicate a period overlapping two calendar years, such as a fiscal, marketing or academic year.

The 2025/26 school year begins on 1 September.

- ✓ Refer to quarters (periods of three months) with the full word and an ordinal number. For ranges, refer to quarters with a capitalised letter “Q” followed by 1, 2, 3 or 4 and the year, separated by a hyphen. In tables and figures, refer to quarters with a capitalised letter “Q” followed by 1, 2, 3 or 4 and the year.

Business investment grew robustly in the fourth quarter of 2024.

The firm saw earnings drop Q2 2020-Q1 2021.

- ✓ Capitalise specific eras and time periods; use lowercase for general ones.

During the Renaissance, texts from ancient times were rediscovered.

Key differences between English and French

English	French
Centuries	
21 st century	<i>XXI^e siècle</i>
Dates	
On 1 and 2 March	<i>Les 1^{er} et 2 mars</i>
Decades	
The 1990s compared with the 2020s	<i>Les années 90 comparées aux années 2020</i>
Hours	
13:20	<i>13h20</i>
Quarters	
Q1#2024 OECD GDP growth continued at a steady pace in the second quarter of 2024	<i>T1#2024 La croissance du PIB de la zone OCDE se poursuivait à un rythme constant au deuxième trimestre 2024.</i>

6 Hyphenation

Used correctly, hyphens improve the clarity of your text and help you to avoid ambiguity. They are essential for compound words and terms.

General rules

- A hyphen joins words or parts of words to form a compound adjective, adverb, noun or verb.
- Hyphens provide clarity. For example, “A small business owner” and “A small-business owner”: the first is a small owner of a business; the second owns a small business.
- Non-breaking hyphens should be used in all instances throughout Word™ text in which the words should be displayed on the same line in the final output.
- When in doubt, consult the word’s entry in the *Oxford English Dictionary*.

See *also*: Capitalisation.

Policy maker, policy-maker or policymaker? Frequent hyphenation questions

- Use **policymaker** (noun) and **policymaking** (noun and adjective); do not hyphenate.
- Use **decision maker** (noun) and **decision making** (noun and adjective); do not hyphenate.
- Use **macroeconomics** (noun), **macroeconomic** (adjective), **microeconomics** (noun) and **microeconomic** (adjective); do not hyphenate.
- Hyphenate **socio-economics** (noun) and **socio-economic** (adjective).
- Use **online** as both an adjective and adverb; do not hyphenate or split into two words.
- Use **website** as one word without hyphenation **but** use **web page** and **web manager** as two-word phrases, without hyphenation.
- Use **worldwide** as both an adjective and adverb; do not hyphenate or split into two words.

Adjectives and adverbs

- When two words together act as a compound adjective modifying a noun, they are generally hyphenated.

Do

- ✓ Use hyphens in compound adjectives before nouns (“attributive” adjectives).
[The report takes an evidence-based approach.](#)
[The well-known economist addressed the conference.](#)

Don't

- ✗ Hyphenate compound adjectives when the first word is an adverb ending in “-ly”.
 - ☹ Targeted training programmes should help to develop a highly-skilled workforce.
 - 😊 Targeted training programmes should help to develop a highly skilled workforce.
- ✗ Use a hyphen if the compound adjective comes after a preposition or noun (“predicate” adjectives).
 - ☹ In the longer-term, the policy measures will boost employment.
 - 😊 In the longer term, the policy measures will boost employment.
 - ☹ The recommendations are evidence-based.
 - 😊 The recommendations are evidence based.

Compound proper nouns and adjectives**Do**

- ✓ Capitalise proper nouns in compound words; if a hyphenated term contains a proper noun and a common element, only capitalise the proper noun.
 - The group was founded to promote Anglo-American relations.
 - Quebec is a French-speaking region in Canada.
- ✓ For title case, capitalise the second word in a hyphenated term.
 - The OECD has released a new report, *Evidence-Based Decision Making in Health Policy*.
- ✓ For joint works, separate the abbreviations or acronyms of the two organisations with a hyphen.
 - The *OECD-FAO Agricultural Outlook*.

See also: Capitalisation; Country and territory names, codes and currencies, and territorial disclaimers.

Don't

- ✗ Capitalise common elements unless they begin the title, heading or sentence.
 - ☹ The problem cannot be solved with Short-term solutions.
 - 😊 Short-term solutions cannot solve the problem.

Dangling hyphens

- Hyphens are often used to show that two or more compound terms share a common part.
- Use them sparingly where the sense is clear and be consistent in your use throughout your text.

See also: Punctuation.

Do

- ✓ Repeat the hyphenated prefix for clarity.
The article compared pre- and post-pandemic data.

Don't

- ✗ Use dangling hyphens if omitting the term creates confusion.
 😞 The university offers courses for under- and postgraduate students.
 😊 The university offers courses for undergraduate and postgraduate students.
- ✗ Omit the second hyphen, or subsequent hyphens, as this may create confusion.
 😞 The course is required for first-, second and third year students.
 😊 The course is required for first-, second- and third-year students.

Doubled hyphens

- Compounds made of more than two words may use multiple hyphens.
The working party met to discuss balance-of-payment deficits.

Do

- ✓ Be consistent in your use of double hyphens throughout your text.
- ✓ Hyphenate the number range in ages:
 - If the age range is being used as an adjective, hyphenate all parts of the compound phrase.
The survey assessed the annual earnings of 15-to-24-year-old workers.
 - If the age range is being used as a noun, do not include “to” and drop the hyphen after the last figure.
The study examines the number of 15-19 year-olds who leave school without a qualification.

Don't

- ✗ Overuse doubled hyphens; rephrase as needed.
 😞 A non-self-financing institution.
 😊 The institution is financed by donors.

Non-breaking hyphens

- Use non-breaking hyphens when you want to keep a word or number on the same line, to preserve meaning and enhance readability.
- Be aware that non-breaking hyphens must be used all instances throughout Word™ text where the words should be displayed on the same line in the final output.
- Insert a non-breaking hyphen using (Ctrl + 8).

Do

- ✓ Use non-breaking hyphens for terms, proper nouns, numbers, negative sums, years, abbreviations and acronyms.

See also: Negative numbers.

Don't

- ✗ Allow line breaks to separate critical compound terms.
- ✗ Use non-breaking hyphens to systematically replace all hyphens.

Prefixes

- Hyphenation with prefixes depends on established usage and clarity.
- Compounds formed with prefixes are often standard combined words rather than hyphenated, whether they are adjectives, adverbs, nouns or verbs ([upfront](#), [underdeveloped](#), [overestimate](#)).
- Adding a prefix to create a compound word often requires a hyphen (ex. cross-country, intra-industry, non-tradeable).

Do

- ✓ Use hyphens after prefixes for clarity, following established usage. Consult the *Oxford English Dictionary* if in doubt.

[The report provides a cross-country analysis of education systems.](#)

- ✓ Hyphenate to prevent confusion with other words.

[He was asked to re-sign \[sign again\] the form vs. He resigned from \[left\] the group.](#)

Don't

- ✗ Hyphenate when the prefix and root are commonly combined.

☹️ [The team will re-write the proposal.](#)

😊 [The team will rewrite the proposal.](#)

Repeated letters

Do

- ✓ Hyphenate double vowels and double or triple consonants (co-ordinate, re-entry, non-negotiable, shell-like).
- ✓ Hyphenate when a prefix and root word result in double letters and the meaning may be ambiguous.
She bought her chicken coop [cage or pen] at the gardening co-op [abbreviated term for a co-operative group or business].

Don't

- ✗ Omit the hyphen in our Organisation's name.
 Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development
 Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development

7 Inclusive language

Using inclusive language reflects the OECD's commitment to equality, diversity and inclusion, ensuring that content is respectful, accurate and accessible to a global audience.

General advice

- Use neutral, factual language and exclude outdated or offensive terms.
- Be respectful – use the terms that individuals and communities use to refer to themselves. When in doubt, ask relevant stakeholders and COM.
- Be aware that language evolves and there is always more to learn.

Age

- Certain terms used to describe older adults may reinforce negative stereotypes about the health and competence of individuals older than 60.

Do

- ✓ Prefer “older” to “elderly” and avoid terms such as “seniors”.
Older people are living longer, healthier lives than ever before.
- ✓ Use balanced age comparisons: “younger, middle-aged and older adults”.
The survey includes samples from younger and older populations.

Disability

- Whether and how to address ability and disability depends on whether it is contextually necessary and on the terminology preferences of the individuals and communities involved.
- **People-first language** emphasises the individual rather than their disability or condition (a person with a traumatic brain injury) and their lived experience.
- **Identity-first language** puts focus on the disability, as a way of reclaiming identity (a Deaf person).

Do

- ✓ Use people-first language in most cases.
- ✓ Use identity-first language if requested by an individual or community.
 The workspace now has ramps to accommodate handicapped people.
 The workspace design facilitates mobility for people who use wheelchairs.

- ✓ Avoid negative framing such as “suffers from” or “victim of”.

☹️ The centre provides activities for Down Syndrome children and other children suffering from congenital disabilities.

😊 The centre provides activities for children living with Down Syndrome and other congenital disabilities.

Gender-neutral language

- Gender-neutral language removes assumptions about gender identity, gender roles and relationships.

Do

- ✓ In general, use gender-neutral terms unless the context requires a gender-specific one. See table below for commonly used gender-neutral alternatives.
- ✓ Use the phrase “different genders” rather than “opposite genders”.

Gender-neutral alternatives to common gendered words

Use	Instead of
graduate, graduates	alumnus/alumni, alumna/alumnae
fellowship, community	brotherhood
business person	businessman, businesswoman
Chair	Chairman, Chairwoman
member of Congress, legislator	Congressman, Congresswoman
Council member	councilman, councilwoman
firefighter	fireman
informal agreement, unwritten agreement	gentleman's agreement
maintenance worker, repair person	handyman
Head of School, Principal	Headmaster, Headmistress
spouse, partner	husband, wife
Distinguished guests (or, informally, “colleagues”, “everyone”, “friends”)	ladies and gentlemen
mail carrier, postal worker	mailman
humanity, humankind	mankind
artificial, synthetic	manmade
workforce, personnel	manpower
parenting	mothering/fathering (as verbs)
police officer	policeman, policewoman
salesperson	salesman, saleswoman

Use	Instead of
fair play, team spirit	sportsmanship
flight attendant	steward, stewardess
server	waiter, waitress

Personal pronouns

- Many people use the standard English pronouns “she/her” and “he/his”; others use “they/them” or other forms.

Do

- ✓ Avoid gender pronouns unless needed for specific context; often a sentence is just as clear without the pronoun.

☹️ Each candidate will be asked to finish his test within 30 minutes.

😊 Each candidate will be asked to finish the test within 30 minutes.

- ✓ Refer to individuals by their self-identified pronouns, whether speaking or writing.
- ✓ Use gender-neutral pronouns (“they/them”) as singular pronouns when gender is unknown, rather than male or female pronouns, or rephrase to avoid using a pronoun.

☹️ Someone left her backpack in the conference room.

😊 Someone left their backpack in the conference room.

Race and ethnicity

- It is imperative to avoid terms that are outdated, offensive, perpetuate stereotypes or imply value judgments.
- Whenever possible, use the racial and/or ethnic terms that the individuals or communities being discussed use themselves.

Do

- ✓ Reference cultural or ethnic identifiers only when relevant to the content.
- ✓ Use terms preferred by the individual or groups described. When in doubt, ask.
- ✓ Prefer specific terms to generic terms.

☹️ The roundtable was made up of Asian policymakers.

😊 The roundtable was made up of policymakers from Japan, Korea and Thailand.

- ✓ Use “minority” as an adjective rather than a noun when referring to individuals and groups.

☹️ The report analyses educational outcomes of minorities in five countries.

😊 The report analyses the educational outcomes of minority groups in five countries.

Sexual orientation

- The language used to describe sexual orientation should be inclusive, respectful and free from assumptions or bias.
- Whenever possible, use accurate and affirming terms that the individuals or communities being discussed use themselves.

Do

- ✓ Use accurate and affirming terms to refer to LGBTIQ+ communities.
 - ☹️ The survey asked participants to indicate their sexual preference.
 - 😊 The survey asked participants to describe their sexual orientation.
- ✓ Avoid terms that imply a preference or are medically outdated.
- ✓ Only reference sexual orientation where relevant or pertinent.
- ✓ Avoid language that explicitly assumes gender identity.
 - ☹️ New households are formed following the marriage of a man and a woman.
 - 😊 Marriages lead to the formation of new households.

8 Italics, roman and bold type

Different kinds and weight of typeface help readers to understand the function of a word or phrase or their importance.

General rules

- Use the styles in O.N.E Author to organise your information and to format your titles and headings. Do not apply bold, italics or underlining to create a hierarchy of information.

Italic type

- Reserve its use for specific elements that need emphasis or differentiation.
- Use sparingly to ensure readability on screen and in print and to preserve its utility for emphasis.

Do

- ✓ Italicise titles of reports, books, journals, newspapers, magazines, databases, and working and policy paper series names. Do not put quotation marks around italicised titles (*OECD Employment Outlook 2025; Moby Dick; The Economist*).
- ✓ Italicise words or phrases from other languages that are not yet naturalised in English.
The nation's policy of autarky stifled international trade opportunities.
- ✓ Use italics for technical terms or variables upon first mention.
The variable X represents economic output.
- ✓ Write Latin abbreviations in italics, except for those listed in the table “Latin terms and abbreviations to put in roman type”.

Don't

- ✗ Overuse italics for emphasis. Excessive use sounds informal, hinders readability and reduces its value for emphasis.
- ✗ Italicise common words or terms from other languages that are widely understood in English (*per capita, laissez-faire, modus operandi*).
- ✗ Italicise titles of sections, chapters, or articles within a publication, or paper titles. Use roman type with double quotation marks instead.
- ✗ Italicise URLs.

Roman type

- Roman type is the default style for the body text and is used for most elements in OECD publications.

Do

- ✓ Use roman type for titles of sections, chapters, articles, papers, policy briefs, country notes, case studies and documents, enclosing them in double quotation marks.

Chapter 4 is titled “Sustainable growth strategies in Europe”.

- ✓ Use roman type for the titles of programmes, legislation, codes and declarations, names of organisations, and proper nouns; do not use italics or bold. Capitalise as appropriate.

The OECD and the ADB collaborated on the project.

The Paris Agreement was adopted by 196 parties.

- ✓ Default to roman type for foreign terms that are commonly used in English.

The results are calculated per capita.

Don't

- ✗ Use roman type for titles of reports, books and periodicals.
- ✗ Use roman type for words or phrases from other languages that are not yet naturalised in English.

Latin terms and abbreviations to put in roman type

ad hoc	ibid.	op.	versus (vs.)
cf.	id., idem	op. cit.	via
circa	i.e.	per capita	vice versa
e.g.	loc. cit.	per annum	
et al.	nota bene (NB)	p.s.	

See also: Abbreviations, acronyms and signs.

Using italic and roman type together

- Pay attention to how you mix italic and roman type together, to ensure clarity and consistency.

Do

- ✓ Note that when the body of a text is in italics, items that normally would be italicised become roman.

Literacy and numeracy skills among adults have largely declined or stagnated over the past decade, according to the second OECD Survey of Adult Skills, published this week.

- ✓ Switch back to roman type for punctuation immediately following italicised words unless the punctuation is part of the italicised phrase.

The report *How's Life in the Digital Age?* has assembled 33 indicators of key impacts of the digital transformation.

Have you read the latest edition of the *OECD Pensions Outlook*?

Bold

- Bold is reserved for signalling emphasis.

Do

- ✓ Use very sparingly, only if essential for meaning. Bold can be considered aggressive looking if overused.

Don't

- ✗ Apply bold as a formatting choice to indicate hierarchy. Use the style settings available in O.N.E Author instead.

Underlining

- Underlining gives an informal and unprofessional look to your text.
- It can also be mistaken for a hyperlink.

Don't

- ✗ Use underlining, unless it appears automatically as part of a URL.

9 Numbers and units of measure

Correctly and consistently expressing numbers and units ensures the accuracy and reliability of OECD work. Be aware of differences between English and French common practices for numbers and units.

General rules

- Depending on the context, ordinal numbers can be written in words (*one, two, three...*), Arabic numerals (*1, 2, 3...*), or Roman numerals (*I, II, III...*).
- There are small but significant differences in how numbers are expressed in English and French, explained in the table at the end of this chapter.

See also: Abbreviations, acronyms and signs; Dates and time; Hyphenation; Punctuation.

Cardinal numbers

- Cardinal numbers express quantity and are used for counting.

Do

- ✓ Express one to ten in words, not figures, **except** for:
 - numbers used with an ISO currency code (*USD 6*)
 - percentages (*5%*)
 - numbers associated with measurement units (*3 km, 80 tonnes, 1 L*)
 - when numbers less than ten and greater than ten occur together in context, write them all in figures
At the meeting, 12 Member countries and 3 non-Member economies raised the issue.
 - numbers followed by “million”, “billion” or “trillion” (*1 million, 3 billion, 5 trillion*)
 - representing scale (*on a scale of 0-10*).
- ✓ Express numbers 11 and above in figures, not words.
- ✓ When two numbers refer to one item, spell out one of them and express the other in figures, following the rules above.
They requested four 1-metre stands.
- ✓ Always write a number out in words if it is the first word in of a sentence.
Twelve OECD Member countries raised the same issue.
- ✓ Always write a number out in words in titles or subtitles.
*The report *Learning beyond Fifteen: Ten Years of PISA* was released in 2012.*
- ✓ For web content, write numbers as digits, not words, with the thousands place separated by a hard space.
- ✓ For web content, write numbers as digits, not words.
- ✓ Round off large numbers, particularly in text.

☹ 1 198 650 000

😊 1.2 billion

See also: Breaks and hard spaces.

Don't

- ✗ Use Roman numerals (I, II, III...), unless as part of an individual's title, the title of a work, or the title of an event or time period.

☹ Mobile phones became widely used at the end of the XXth century.

😊 Mobile phones became widely used at the end of the 20th century.

☹ King Richard the 3rd of England died in 1485.

😊 King Richard III of England died in 1485.

Decimal fractions

- Numbers containing decimal fractions should always be written in numbers.
- Decimal fractions are always plural.

Do

- ✓ Express decimal fractions in numerals.

- ✓ Use a decimal point, never a comma or other mark.

The average family has 2.4 children.

- ✓ Use a zero, never a blank space.

0.45 (not .45)

- ✓ Round currency up or down to a full number or give the number to two decimal places.

AUS 1 (instead of AUS 0.92); USD 0.02 (for two cents) EUR 0.20 (for 20 cents).

Non-decimal fractions**Do**

- ✓ Express non-decimal fractions in words.

- ✓ Hyphenate the numbers in a fraction regardless of whether it is being used as an adjective or noun.

- ✓ In general, use only readily recognisable fractions such as one-third, one-quarter, one-half.

Three-quarters of the legislators voted for the resolution.

The Senate approved the bill by a two-thirds majority.

Don't

- ✗ Use numerals to express non-decimal fractions.
 - ☹️ Over ¼ of the class was absent.
 - 😊 Over one-fourth of the class was absent.
- ✗ Use less recognisable forms of fractions.
 - ☹️ The survey showed two-eighths of the territory was uninhabitable.
 - 😊 The survey showed that 25% of the territory was uninhabitable.

Negative numbers

- Negative numbers always have a value that is less than zero. This is indicated with a minus sign proceeding the numeral (-446.2).

Do

- ✓ Use a non-breaking hyphen or the minus key for the minus sign, to ensure the sign and number stay on the same line.

Don't

- ✗ Leave a space between the minus sign and the number.
- ✗ If referring to currencies, put the ISO code first, then the negative number (CAD -225).

See *also*: Breaks and hard spaces; Hyphenation.

Ordinal numbers

- Ordinal numbers express position in an order or series.

Do

- ✓ Use ordinal numbers sparingly. Overuse is distracting for the reader, particularly in lists.

Don't

- ✗ Use the adverbial form of ordinal numbers (firstly, secondly...). Reword the sentence.
 - ☹️ The proposed legislation will help local businesses in two ways. Firstly, it will attract investment to the area. Secondly, it will fund training programmes.
 - 😊 The proposed legislation will help local businesses by attracting investment and funding training programmes.

Percentages

Do

- ✓ Use “%” in all text and graphics, except in publication titles, chapter titles, section headings, and when the percentage is the first word of the sentence.
- ✓ Use “%” or “per cent” in a text when referring to a defined amount.
- ✓ Use “per cent” (not “%” or “percent”) when the percentage expressed is the first word of the sentence.

Ninety per cent of the participants agreed with the chair’s proposal, but 10% did not.

- ✓ Use “percentage” when referring to a general proportion or share.
A small percentage of the students needed extra tutoring.
- ✓ Spell out “percentage points” on first usage followed by (p.p.) and use “p.p.” thereafter.
The survival rate of supported firms was approximately 2.5 p.p. higher than the one of non-supported firms after 12 months.

- ✓ In general, for a percentage that is a decimal fraction, round to one decimal point. If one or more percentages are a decimal fraction, express any whole number percentages in the same sentence or list with the whole number followed by “.0”.

The inflation rate was 2.2% in November 2024, up from 2.0% in October.

- ✓ Repeat the % sign after each number in a series.
Last week, 45%, 55% and 65% of the trains, planes and buses ran on time, respectively.
- ✓ Repeat the “%” sign when per cent ranges are separated by prepositions but not when the range is hyphenated.

On average, 10% to 20% of food is wasted every day.

On average, 10-20% of food is wasted every day.

Don’t

- ✗ Use the “%” symbol with a number written as a word; use the numeral instead.
- ✗ Put a space between the number and the percentage sign.

☹️ The hurricane damaged fifty % of the buildings.

😊 The hurricane damaged 50% of the buildings.

- ✗ Use the % sign with non-decimal fractions.

☹️ The price was cut by ¼%.

😊 The price was cut by 0.25%.

See *also*: Breaks and hard spaces.

Numbers with four or more digits

- For clarity and simplicity, the OECD has adopted the rule that, for all texts in all languages, numbers containing four or more digits are broken by spaces, not punctuation marks.

See *also*: Punctuation.

Do

- ✓ Always use a hard space to separate numbers of four or more digits; never use punctuation nor run numbers together (4 000, 1 275 103, 8 619 673 021).

Don't

- ✗ Break numbers across lines. Use hard spaces to indicate the thousands space. No space is needed if referring to a year, page number, legislation, an address or for online content (2025, p. 1001).

Units of measure

- Although most countries and economies use the International System of Units (SI), some continue to use local systems. Use units of measure most appropriate for the topic being discussed.

Do

- ✓ Separate a number from a unit of measure with a hard space.
- ✓ Always capitalise units of measure that are derived from a proper name (A [Ampère], Pa [Pascal], kWh [Watt]).

See *also*: Breaks and hard spaces.

Don't

- ✗ Italicise or put in bold units of measure.
- ✗ Invent symbols or abbreviations for units of measure. See the table below.

Abbreviations for units of measure

Length		
mm	millimetre	
cm	centimetre	
m	metre	
km	kilometre	
in	inch	
ft	foot	
yd	yard	
mi	mile	
Surface		
m²	square metre	
km²	square kilometre	The SI suggests the use of “km ² ” rather than “hectare” (ha).
ft²	square foot	
sq yd	square yard	
Weight		
µg	microgramme	
dg	decigramme	
g	gramme	
kg	kilogramme	
oz	ounce	
lb	pound	
t	tonne	
Mt	million tonnes, megatonnes	Use “Mt” to indicate million tonnes or megatonnes when it is used frequently in the text; otherwise, it should be spelled out. Remember to spell out “Mt” on first use.

Volume (metrics units, SI – litre-based)

The SI recommends using an uppercase “L” to avoid confusion with the number “1”.

daL	decalitre	
hL	hectolitre	
L	litre	

Volume (imperial/US customary units)

pt	pint	
qt	quart	
gal	gallon	

Temperature		
°C	degree Celsius	Note that Fahrenheit is not used in OECD publications.
Time		
s	second	
min	minute	
hr	hour	
y	year	
Large numbers		
thsd	thousand	Also k (kilo)
mln	million	Also M (mega)
bln	billion	Also G (giga)
tln	trillion	Also T (tera)
Other		
A, kA	ampere, kiloampere	
Bq	becquerel	Unit of radioactivity
J, kJ	joule, kilojoule	
mph	miles per hour	
km/h	kilometres per hour	
kW/h	kilowatt hour	
pkm	passenger-kilometre	Unit measuring how much passenger transport a system provides
px	pixel	
tkm	tonne(s)-kilometre(s)	Unit measuring the volume and distance of freight transport
t eq. CO₂	tonne of CO ₂ equivalent	Unit measuring the climate warming effect of 1 tonne of carbon dioxide
vkm	1 vehicle travelling 1 kilometre	Unit measuring the total distance travelled by vehicles
V	volt	Note that “volt” is lowercase when spelt in full
W	watt	Note that “watt” is lowercase when spelt in full

Key differences between English and French

English	French
Four digits and above	
For coherency across the official languages, the OECD chooses to use spaces rather than punctuation marks for numbers containing four or more digits (2 618, 32 518, 7 519 000).	
Fractions	
one-third, two-thirds, three-quarters, etc.	<i>un tiers, deux tiers, trois quarts, etc.</i>
Large numbers	
<i>International System of Units (SI) scale, short form:</i>	<i>International System of Units (SI) scale, long form:</i>
million = one million (10 ⁶)	
billion = thousand million (10 ⁹)	billion = mille milliards (10 ¹²)
trillion = thousand billion (10 ¹²)	trillion = milliard de milliards (10 ¹⁸)
Ordinal numeral adjectives	
1 st	<i>1^{er}, 1^{re}</i>
2 nd	<i>2^e, 2^d/2^{de}</i>
3 rd	<i>3^e</i>
4 th , etc.	<i>4^e, etc.</i>
Percentages	
5%	<i>5#%</i>
Plural numbers	
<i>All numbers except 1 generally take the plural:</i>	<i>Only numbers 2 or higher take the plural:</i>
0.7 children per family, 1 child per family, 1.5 children per family	<i>0.7 enfant par famille, 1.5 enfant par famille, 2 enfants par famille</i>
-0.5 degrees, -1 degree, -2 degrees	<i>-0.5 degré, -1 degré, -2 degrés</i>
Second number in groups of ten	
twenty-one	<i>vingt et un</i>
thirty-one	<i>trente et un</i>
forty-one	<i>quarante et un</i>
fifty-one	<i>cinquante et un</i>
sixty-one	<i>soixante et un</i>
seventy-one	<i>soixante et onze</i>

10 The OECD and other international organisations

International organisations, including the OECD, have particular identities, rules for acronyms and spelling, and ways of presenting themselves. Using correct names, acronyms and titles ensures clarity and avoids offense.

Referring to the OECD

- The OECD's full name is the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. Note the British spelling of "organisation" and the hyphen in "co-operation". The acronym is OECD.
- The Organisation's history, membership, wider engagement, ways of working, Secretariat and more are presented on the OECD website: <https://www.oecd.org/en/about.html>.

Do

- ✓ Give the full name followed by the acronym in parentheses on first usage and the acronym or "the Organisation" thereafter.

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) is based in Paris, France. The OECD had 38 Member countries as of January 2025. The Organisation is considering the accession of several other countries.

- ✓ Adopt language and key facts from <https://www.oecd.org/about> when presenting the Organisation orally or in writing.
- ✓ Use the corporate presentation available here:
https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/pac/kc/Communications/Comms%20preparation/External%20Communication/OECD_CorporatePresentation-EN.pptx

Don't

- ✗ Use personal pronouns to refer to the OECD in formal writing.

☹️ We find that unemployment dropped in Q1.

☹️ OECD findings show that unemployment dropped in Q1.

☹️ Several of our economists participated in the seminar.

☹️ Several OECD economists participated in the seminar.

Referring to OECD Members, non-Members, Key Partners and accession candidate countries

- The OECD has specific naming and style conventions for Members, non-Members, Key Partners and accession candidate countries. Refer to documentation provided by LEG: <https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/leg/Pages/Home.aspx#Countries%2c%20Territories%20and%20Diplomatic%20Sensitivities>.
- If in doubt, or if asked to apply different naming, contact LEG at LEGILU@oecd.org and the Global Relations and Co-operation Directorate at GRCDIRPARTNERSHIPS@oecd.org, for clarification.

See also: Capitalisation.

Do

- ✓ Capitalise “Member” in OECD Member, OECD Members, OECD Member country and OECD Member countries.
- ✓ Refer to Brazil, China, India, Indonesia, and South Africa as “Key Partners”, capitalising both words.
- ✓ Prefer “partner”, “country” or “economy” when referring to non-Members.
- ✓ Use “economy” rather than “country” when referring to sensitive territorial areas.
- ✓ Refer to a country with whom Council has opened accession discussions as an “accession candidate country”.

The OECD has 38 Members and 8 accession candidate countries. The Organisation works with more than 100 partner countries and economies around the world, including 5 Key Partners.

- ✓ Capitalise “Associate”, “Participant” and “Invitee” if the terms are being used in the context of non-Member participation in the work of in OECD subsidiary bodies in line with the general principals set out in Revised Resolution of the Council on Partnerships in OECD Bodies [[C\(2012\)100/REV2/FINAL](#)].

Don't

- ✗ Capitalise “country” as part of “Member country”, “economy” or “accession candidate country” unless the phrase is a part of a title.
- ✗ Refer to “OECD Members” as a geographic grouping; prefer “OECD area”, particularly after a preposition.

☹️ Aquaculture is continuing to grow in importance, including in the OECD Members.

😊 Aquaculture is continuing to grow in importance, including in the OECD area.

- ✗ Capitalise the term “observer”.

Using OECD official titles

- OECD official titles use specific capitalisation, hyphenation and spelling.

See also: Capitalisation; Hyphenation.

Do

- ✓ Use the following:
 - Secretary-General, Deputy Secretary-General, Deputies Secretary-General
 - director, deputy director
 - chair, vice-chair, former chair; vice-chairperson, former chairperson
 - High-level Group
- ✓ Be consistent throughout your text.

Don't

- ✗ Alter or invent hyphenation in OECD official titles.

Referring to other international organisations**Do**

- ✓ Spell out the organisation's full name on a first reference in a paper, chapter, web page or article, followed by its acronym or abbreviation in parentheses.
- ✓ Follow the spelling used by the organisation itself, which you can check on the organisation's official website.
- ✓ Use "European Union" rather than the "European Community".
- ✓ Distinguish between the "Council of Europe" (an IO distinct from the EU), the "European Council" (where EU heads of state set general political directions and priorities) and the "Council of the European Union" (where national ministers from each EU country meet to negotiate and adopt EU laws).

International organisations' names and their acronyms or abbreviations

Organisation	Acronym or abbreviation
Asian Development Bank	ADB
African Development Bank	AfDB
African Union	AU
Association of Southeast Asian Nations	ASEAN
Council of Europe	CoE
European Bank for Reconstruction and Development	EBRD
European Investment Bank	EIB
European Central Bank	ECB
European Commission	the Commission
European Economic Area	EEA
European Free Trade Association	EFTA
European Union	EU
Financial Action Task Force	FATF
Food and Agriculture Organization	FAO
International Energy Agency	IEA
International Atomic Energy Agency	IAEA
International Bank for Reconstruction and Development	IBRD
International Civil Aviation Organization	ICAO
International Labour Organization	ILO
International Monetary Fund	IMF

Organisation	Acronym or abbreviation
International Maritime Organization	IMO
International Organization for Migration	IOM
Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change	IPCC
Inter-Parliamentary Union	IPU
International Telecommunication Union	ITU
Nuclear Energy Agency	NEA
Nordic Council	none
Organization for Security and Co-operation in Europe	OSCE
Union for the Mediterranean	UfM
Joint United Nations Programme on HIV and AIDS	UNAIDS
United Nations Conference on Trade and Development	UNCTAD
United Nations Development Programme	UNDP
United Nations Environment Programme	UNEP
United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization	UNESCO
United Nations General Assembly	UNGA
United Nations Human Settlements Programme	UN-HABITAT
United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees	UNHCR
United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund	UNICEF
World Tourism Organisation	UNWTO
World Bank	WB
World Health Organization	WHO
World Intellectual Property Organization	WIPO
World Meteorological Organization	WMO
World Trade Organization	WTO

11 Punctuation

Punctuation marks clarify meaning and indicate pauses, stops or shifts in tone. They help to separate ideas, signal emphasis and convey relationships between parts of a text.

General rules

- Be consistent in the punctuation used throughout the text.
- Use punctuation thoughtfully, without excessive repetition of marks that may confuse the reader.
- Match punctuation to tone and style; some marks may be more appropriate in informal writing than formal.
- In English, never put a space before a colon, comma, exclamation point, full stop (period), question mark or semi-colon.

See also: Capitalisation.

Are Oxford commas necessary? No... and yes.

The Oxford comma, or serial comma, is used before a conjunction (such as “and”, “or”) in a list of three or more items. It is more commonly used in American English. OECD usage broadly aligns with British English usage; avoid using the Oxford comma unless necessary for clarity.

- Do not use a comma before the final item in a list.
She had soup, bread and salad for lunch.
- Do put a comma before the final item in a list if its omission would cause confusion.
They had soup, bread and cheese, and salad for lunch.

Ampersand

- Represented by “&”.
- The ampersand represents the word “and”.
- It is commonly used in company names and abbreviations as well as in informal writing.

Do

- ✓ Use the ampersand when part of an official name or title and when commonly used in an abbreviation (*Johnson & Johnson, R&D*).

Don't

- ✗ Replace “and” with the ampersand in regular text or formal writing.

☹️ The report covers trends in health & education.

😊 The report covers trends in health and education.

Apostrophe

- Represented by “’”.
- Apostrophes are used with “s” to indicate possession.
- In informal English, apostrophes can be used to indicate contraction.

Do

- ✓ Place an apostrophe followed by “s” to indicate possession for singular nouns, plural nouns that do not end in “s” and proper names (including those ending in “s”).

They considered the prime minister’s suggestion.

The children’s next school holiday is in April.

The airline lost Jane’s suitcase but not James’s suitcase.

- ✓ Place an apostrophe after the “s” for plural nouns that end in “s”.

The ministers’ decision was unanimous.

- ✓ Place the apostrophe after the last name or item in a series.

They met in Jean and Emilia’s office to review the report.

Don't

- ✗ Use an apostrophe to contract words (“can’t” instead of “cannot”, “don’t” for “do not” or “they’re” for “they are”) except for informal text where character counts are limited, such as social media.

- ✗ Confuse “its” (a possessive pronoun) and “it’s” (a contraction of “it is”) or “your” (a possessive pronoun) and “you’re” (a contraction of “you are”).

- ✗ Use an apostrophe and “s” in decades or abbreviations.

☹️ The OECD and several other IO’s were founded in the 1960’s.

😊 The OECD and several other IOs were founded in the 1960s.

Breaks and hard spaces

- Hard spaces between words ensure that words are not split during the document formatting stage.

Do

- ✓ Create hard spaces in Word™ by holding Ctrl + Shift and pressing the space bar.
- ✓ Place a hard space (#) in the cases listed below.

Required use of hard spaces

Rule	Example
Between a person's title and their name	Mr#Smith, Dr#Jones
Between a numeral and the unit or other word accompanying it	page#10, 37#firms, 19th#century
Within numerals made up of four or more digits	20#000#students
Between the day and month (but not month and year) in a date	15#January 2003
In country names	United#States
In currencies	EUR#50, USD#10#million
In units of measure (except °C and %)	580#kg, 215#cm, 42#hL
Other examples (depending on context, such as initials or abbreviations)	E.B.#White Smith,#J. (2025) French government e.g.#[text],#etc., et#al.

Colon

- Represented by “:”.
- Colons can be used to introduce information or clarification, or for emphasis.
- Use colons sparsely: overuse reduces readability.

Do

- ✓ Use colons to lead into a list, explanation or elaboration or an indented quotation. In most such cases, the colon is preceded by an independent clause.

The OECD is located on two sites: one in Paris and one in Boulogne.

- ✓ Use colons to separate titles and subtitles.

Global Trends in Government Innovation 2024: Fostering Human-Centred Public Services

See also: Capitalisation; Lists.

Don't

- ✗ Use more than one colon in a sentence.
- ✗ Put a space before a colon.
- ✗ Capitalise the first word after a colon (except for titles).

Comma

- Represented by “,”.
- A comma indicates a brief pause in a sentence. It may also be used to set off specific clauses, phrases or appositives as well as to separate items in a list.

Do

- ✓ Use commas to separate items in a list.
The Secretary-General visited Japan, Australia and New Zealand.
- ✓ Use a comma to set off a relative clause or other element that is not part of the main sentence.
Mr Smith, the committee chair, recommended a fully independent enquiry.
- ✓ Use a comma before conjunction introducing an independent clause.
It is one thing to know a gene's chemical structure, but quite another to understand its actual function.
- ✓ Place a comma between adjectives if each modifies the noun alone and if you could insert the word “and” instead of the comma.
The board of directors called for swift, extensive changes.

Don't

- ✗ Use commas:
 - after “i.e.” or “e.g.”
 - before parentheses
 - before or after en-dashes
 - before “and” or “or” at the end of a sequence of items, unless one of the items includes another “and” or “or”.

Ellipses

- Represented by three dots “...”.
- In formal writing, an ellipsis (plural: ellipses) are used to show that text has been omitted or left unsaid.
- When placed in the middle of a sentence, an ellipsis suggests that something has been taken out; when placed at the end of the sentence, an ellipsis suggests there is more that could be said.

See also: Quotations.

Do

- ✓ Use to indicate material omitted from a quote, with a hard space placed before and after the ellipses (#...#).

This includes broader sectoral policies to induce emissions reductions by all actors along the supply chain ... as well as policies that induce lifestyle or consumption changes in end users.

- ✓ Place brackets around the ellipsis when a full line or paragraph has been omitted, with a hard space placed before and after (#[...]#).

Governments are using open data initiatives, which foster transparency, accountability and citizen engagement, to improve public services. [...] Open data allows for a collaborative approach to problem-solving.

Don't

- ✗ Break an idea across section headings with ellipses; this is confusing for readers.
- ✗ Use an ellipsis to indicate a pause or to replace “etc.” or “and so on”.
- ✗ Put parentheses “()” around an ellipsis.
- ✗ Put spaces between the dots in an ellipsis.

En-dash

- Represented by “–”.
- En-dashes are used to set off information or add a phrase or clause to the sentence.
- En-dashes can be confused with em-dashes and hyphens. See the table “Distinguishing between hyphens and dashes”.

Do

- ✓ Use en-dashes in pairs to set off information that is not part of the main sentence, but which you wish to highlight or stress.

- ✓ Use a space before and after each en-dash.

The conference – for which more than 1 000 participants had registered – lasted three days.

- ✓ Use one en-dash to add a phrase explaining or elaborating on what has gone before.

The meeting was running late – their discussion had been absorbing.

Don't

- ✗ Use dashes – of any kind – in titles.
- ✗ Combine dashes with other punctuation; an interjected phrase that starts with a dash must end with one.
 - 😬 In a rush – it was late, he dashed out the door.
 - 😬 In a rush – it was late – he dashed out the door.
- ✗ Use em-dashes (—).

Distinguishing between hyphens and dashes

Type	Symbol	How to insert	Keystroke
Hyphen	-	Key on English keyboard: To the right of zero (0)	x2D + ALT x
En-dash	–	Windows shortcut: Ctrl + minus sign	2013 + ALT x
Em-dash	—	Do not use in OECD work	Do not use in OECD work

Exclamation mark

- Represented by “!”.
- Exclamation marks are **not** used in formal writing. They may be used very sparingly in informal writing.

Forward slash

- They are used to indicate time periods and in expressing ratios and measurements.
- They are also used in internet addresses.

See *also*: Hyphenation; Time periods.

Do

- ✓ Use for a period overlapping two calendar years.
The accounts covered 2017/18.
- ✓ Use in ratios.
Price/earnings, reserves/production, risk/reward, USD 100/t, CO₂/km².

Don't

- ✗ Use a slash mark (/) to replace “or”.
 - ☹️ To go through customs you may present your ID card/passport/both.
 - 😊 To go through customs you may present your ID card, passport or both.
- ✗ Use “and/or” when “or” is sufficient.
- ✗ Use a slash for a period of two or more full years; instead, use a hyphen.
 - ☹️ 2017/19
 - 😊 2017-2019 (but 2017/19 is correct to indicate a period that overlaps two years but is less than two full years).
- ✗ Use a slash to link terms that are usually linked by a hyphen.
 - ☹️ A Paris/New York flight
 - 😊 A Paris-New York flight
- ✗ Replace “per”, “a” or “an” with a slash with units of measure.
 - ☹️ 100 kilometres/hour or 100 km/h
 - 😊 100 kilometres per hour.

Full stop (period)

- Represented by “.”.
- The full stop, or period, indicates the end of a sentence or statement.

Do

- ✓ Use a full stop to complete a sentence and follow it by a space.
- ✓ Place a full stop at end of all paragraphs.
- ✓ Put the full stop inside quotation marks when it ends the quotation as well as the sentence in which it appears. Place the full stop outside quotation marks where the quotation itself does not end with a full stop.
 - The chairperson said, “This meeting is concluded.”
 - The report often referred to “ups and downs”.
- ✓ Place a full stop after abbreviations such “etc.” and where generally customary (“i.e.” or “e.g.”).
- ✓ Include full stops when needed to avoid confusion.
 - No, they do not live at No. 20, their house is at No. 25.

See *also*: Breaks and hard spaces.

Don't

- ✗ Use a full stop after headings, titles, or bulleted items unless they form a complete sentence.
- ✗ Use a full stop if an abbreviation consists of the first and last letters of a word: [Mr](#), [Ms](#), [Ltd](#), [Dr](#).

See *also*: Abbreviations, acronyms and signs.

Lists

- Lists can be useful to highlight important points or enumerate items.
- Bulleted lists are set off from the text, with a bullet point for each item.
- Numbered lists are run into the text and can use [Arabic numbers \(1, 2, 3\)](#), [Roman numerals \(i, ii, iii\)](#) or [lowercase letters \(a, b, c\)](#) as long as the choice is applied consistently.
- See table “Types of lists”.

Do

- ✓ Use lists sparingly, to avoid interrupting the flow of your text.
- ✓ Apply the same grammatical structure to each item in the list.
- ✓ For lists with complete sentences, use a capital letter to start the first word, and a full stop.
- ✓ For lists with incomplete sentences, use a lowercase letter to start the first word and no punctuation.
- ✓ Use bullet points, numbers (Arabic numbers or Roman numerals) or lowercase letters in roman type, to mark the items in the list.

Types of lists

Type	Example
Bulleted list with complete sentences	To avoid delays with your publication: • Consult COM Support if you have questions. • Submit your Kappa form six weeks in advance. • Keep the publications team in COM apprised of any unexpected changes or delays. • Send the complete manuscript to TRA as early as possible.
Numbered list with complete sentences (shown here with Arabic numerals; the same list style applies for Roman numerals)	PISA results show that: 1. Girls perform better in reading. 2. Boys perform better in mathematics. 3. Girls and boys perform better in reading when they read for pleasure in their free time.
All lists with incomplete sentences	The following components are essential to your publication: • Title page • Copyright page • Foreword • Executive summary
Run-in list in a paragraph	PISA results show that: girls perform better in reading; boys perform better in mathematics; and girls and boys perform better in reading when they read for pleasure in their free time.

Parentheses

- Represented by “()”.
- Parentheses set off material that is not a part of the main sentence, such as an explanation. They are also used for in-text citation of a source.

Do

- ✓ Use sparingly to avoid jarring the reader; often commas can replace parentheses.
 - ☹ Mr Blair (the Prime Minister of the United Kingdom) addressed the United Nations.
 - 😊 Mr Blair, the Prime Minister of the United Kingdom, addressed the United Nations.
- ✓ Put the full stop **before** the closing parentheses mark if the phrase in parentheses is a complete sentence.

(The OECD Council met last week.)
- ✓ Put the full stop **after** the closing parentheses mark if the phrase in parentheses is not a complete sentence.

The committee met to discuss several topics (the latest report, new data and a project proposal).

Question mark

- Represented by “?”.
- Question marks are used to indicate direct questions.

See *also*: Quotations.

Do

- ✓ Use to mark direct questions, replacing the full stop.
- ✓ Use a capital letter to start the first word after the question mark.

Did the reporter read the policy paper? Apparently not.

Don't

- ✗ Use a question mark for indirect questions.

☹️ The reporter was asked whether she had read the report?

😊 The reporter was asked whether she had read the report.

Quotation marks

- Quotation marks come in pairs: one mark to open the quote and another to close it.
- Single quotation marks are indicated with (‘ ’), while double quotation marks are indicated with (“ ”). Each are used in different ways.
- Quotation marks enclose direct speech, quotations, titles or terms.

See *also*: Full stop (period); Quotations.

Do

- ✓ Use double quotation marks for direct speech, short quotations, titles or terms.
“The report discusses financial markets in Central and Eastern Europe.”
- ✓ Use single quotation marks for quotes within quotes
“The report discusses ‘grey markets’ in Central and Eastern Europe.”
- ✓ Place punctuation after the quotation mark when the quoted material does not end a sentence.
The report discusses “grey markets”, which are of particular concern in emerging economies.
- ✓ Place punctuation within the quotation mark if the quoted material ends with a full stop.
The report concluded that “continued growth is uncertain. The outlook remains cloudy.”
- ✓ Put punctuation after the close quotation mark if the quoted material itself does not end with a full stop and ends the sentence.
The speaker asserted that monetary policy must remain “vigilant”.

Don't

- ✗ Use any quotation marks to set off quotations longer than five lines.
- ✗ Use single quotation marks for stand-alone terms.
- ☹️ This report refers to all 'participants' as defined below.
- 😊 This report refers to all "participants" as defined below.

Semi-colon

- Represented by “;”.
- Semi-colons connect clauses that could stand alone as separate sentences, but which are linked for emphasis or because they are related.
- Semi-colons also clarify complex lists.

See *also*: Colon; Lists.

Do

- ✓ Use semi-colons to join related clauses.
 - ✓ Separate items in complex lists that contain commas.
- The committee reviewed the report; approval was unanimously given.
- They visited Paris, France; Rome, Italy; and Athens, Greece.

Don't

- ✗ Use semi-colons in simple lists.
- ☹️ They invested in Apple; IBM; Dell; and Microsoft.
- 😊 They invested in Apple, IBM, Dell and Microsoft.
- ✗ Use semi-colons and colons interchangeably.
- ☹️ The team has one goal; success.
- 😊 The team has one goal: success.

Square brackets

- Represented by “[]”.
- The note symbol is placed within square brackets and in subscript (OCDE, 2025_[1]).

See *also*: Quotations.

Do

- ✓ Use square brackets within other forms of punctuation, usually parentheses, to provide additional information or explanation.

(We also administered the Beck Depression Inventory [BDI; Beck, Steer, & Garbin, 1988], but those results are not reported here.)

- ✓ Use within direct quotes to note information not in the original.

The chair said, “At this point [2022], the outlook is still unclear.”

Key differences between English and French

English	French
Punctuation and hard spaces	
Spaces are not placed between the last word and before punctuation, only after it. <i>Source: OECD (2024), OECD Economic Outlook, Volume 2024 Issue 2, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/d8814e8b-en.</i>	A space is placed after the last word and before a colon, semi-colon, exclamation point and question mark; spaces are placed before and after quotation marks. <i>Source : OCDE (2024), Perspectives économiques de l'OCDE, Volume 2024 Numéro 2, Éditions OCDE, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/0481cf21-fr.</i>
Quotation marks	
Spaces are only placed before the opening mark and after the closing mark (if it is not followed by other punctuation).	Spaces are placed before and after quotation marks.
Double quotation marks (“ ”) are used for quotations and single (‘ ’) quotation marks are used for quotes within quotations.	French quotation marks (« ») are used for quotations and English double quotation marks (“ ”) are used for quotes within quotes.
Punctuation appears inside quotation marks if it concludes the phrase or sentence. “Taxes play a vital role in limiting the social and economic costs of smoking,” OECD Secretary-General Mathias Cormann said.	Punctuation appears outside quotation marks regardless of whether it concludes the phrase or sentence. « La fiscalité contribue de manière déterminante à limiter les coûts sociaux et économiques de la consommation de tabac », a déclaré le Secrétaire général de l'OCDE, Mathias Cormann.

12 Quotations

It is essential to correctly format your quotations and cite their sources. Doing so ensures that you respect copyright and avoid plagiarism. It also helps other readers to identify and access your source materials.

General rules

- A quotation is a passage taken from another work and clearly indicated as such. A quotation can also present the words and thoughts of third parties reported in the text.
- In order to avoid plagiarism, always fully cite your sources. Further information on plagiarism is available at <https://com-apps.oecd.org/com-guidance-portal/en/how-to/how-to-avoid-plagiarism>.

See *also*: Bibliographical references, citations and notes; Punctuation.

Long quotes

- Use a separate, indented paragraph for quotes of more than five lines.
- Use the correct O.N.E Author style for long quotes and do not add quotation marks.
- Insert the author name in the “Reference Management” tool in Word™. The reference number will be automatically generated when the reference is added to your bibliography.
- Cite the source in parentheses at the end of the quote and do not put a full stop after the citation.

The global economy has remained resilient this year, despite differences in the strength of activity across countries and sectors. Inflation has continued to moderate and headline inflation is now back to central bank targets in most economies. Labour market tightness has also eased, although unemployment rates generally remain at or near historical lows. However, risks are casting a shadow over what is otherwise a relatively benign central projection. Key risks pertain to the intensification of geopolitical tensions, inflation turning out more persistent than anticipated and a sharp repricing of risk in financial markets. (OECD, 2024^[1])

Short quotes

- Insert quotes of five lines or less into the running text, using double quotation marks (“ ”) and in-text citation.

“The global economy has proved resilient. Inflation has declined further towards central bank targets, while growth has remained stable,” OECD Secretary-General Mathias Cormann said (OECD, 2024).

Quotations and punctuation

- Place punctuation inside the quotation marks if the quote ends the clause or sentence; place outside the quotation marks if not.

“Inflation in the OECD is expected to ease further, from 5.4% in 2024 to 3.8% in 2025 and 3.0% in 2026.” (OECD, 2024)

“Inflation in the OECD is expected to ease further” in 2025 and 2026 (OECD, 2024).

- Use single quotation marks (‘ ’) for quotes of more than one word within quotes.

“In Figure 2.15, ‘green technology’ refers to a firm that in the previous two years has invested in products or technologies that reduce its energy consumption or improve its environmental footprint.”

- Replace omitted words or phrases with an ellipsis (...); replace omitted paragraphs with an ellipsis in square brackets ([...]).

“A common indicator of labour shortages is the ratio of the number of job vacancies to the number of unemployed individuals. ... By late 2023, vacancies per unemployed had returned to their pre-pandemic trend in the United States, the euro area and Japan.” (OECD, 2024)

“In the past few years, the global economy has demonstrated remarkable resilience despite being subject to major shocks. Global trade has also been recovering. [...] Trade has been an important engine of global growth, job creation and declining poverty in the past decades.” (OECD, 2024)

- Place square brackets “[]” around that has been added to the quotation.

“Trade has been an important engine of growth, job creation and declining poverty in the past decades [in all OECD countries].” (OECD, 2024)

- Use a capital letter to start the quote if the quote is at the start of the sentence or if it follows a colon. Use a lowercase letter if the quote is part of a run on phrase.

“Another source of risk comes from the public finances, as public debt remains at elevated levels,” noted the OECD Economic Outlook. (OECD, 2024)

The OECD Economic Outlook argued that “some emerging market economies and low-income countries are now in debt distress”. (OECD, 2024)

See *also*: Ellipses; Square brackets.

Key differences between English and French

English	French
Double quote marks (“example”) are placed around quotes and single quote marks (‘example’) are used for quotes within quotes. As the committee chair noted, “The Recommendation aims to help Member countries, as well as non-Members who have signed the Recommendation (hereafter ‘adherents’), to finalise or update their national strategies for fighting financial crime.”	Double quote marks called “guillemets” (« example ») are placed around quotes and English style double quote marks (“example”) are used for quotes within quotes. <i>Comme l’a rappelé le président du Comité, « La Recommandation vise à aider les pays Membres ainsi que les non-Membres y ayant adhéré (ci-après les “Adhérents”) à mettre au point ou à mettre à jour leurs stratégies nationales pour lutter contre la délinquance fiscale ».</i>
When reporting direct speech, the comma is placed before the closing quotation mark. “Taxes play a vital role in limiting the social and economic costs of smoking,” OECD Secretary-General Mathias Cormann said.	When reporting direct speech, the comma is placed after the closing quotation mark. <i>« La fiscalité contribue de manière déterminante à limiter les coûts sociaux et économiques de la consommation de tabac », a déclaré le Secrétaire général de l’OCDE, Mathias Cormann.</i>

13 Spelling and usage

Using correct, consistent spelling in your content conveys your meaning clearly and preserves the Organisation's reputation for accuracy and quality. Selecting the correct terms is also essential.

British English spelling

- Use British English spelling in all OECD content.
- The *Concise Oxford English Dictionary* is the OECD's dictionary of choice.

Do

- ✓ Set your language in Word™ to “English (United Kingdom)”.
- ✓ Use “-ise” endings, not “-ize” (“organise”, “realise”).
- ✓ Use “-our” endings, not “-or” (“labour”, “honour”).
- ✓ Use “-re” endings, not “-er” (“centre”, “metre”).
- ✓ Use double consonants when adding endings to words (“travelling”, “focussed”, “labelled”).
- ✓ Respect the use of American spelling in the names of US institutions or of institutions that use US spelling.

The International Labour Organization is based in Geneva.

Choosing the right words

- Use clear, simple language to communicate effectively with audiences who might not be native English speakers or experts in the subject.
- Avoid foreign words and expressions (*ceteris paribus*, *inter alia*, *ipso facto*). They make your writing harder to understand and alternatives exist in English (“other things being equal”, “among other things”, “by the fact of”).
- Be aware that some words in English may be pronounced or spelt similarly yet have very different meanings or may have similar yet not interchangeable meanings. Refer to the table “Commonly confused English words”.
- Take care to choose the word that actually expresses your meaning. The table “Commonly misused words in English” helps you to navigate key English words that are often used incorrectly.
- Note that some words in English and French share the same meaning but are not spelt exactly the same. The table “Commonly confused spellings of similar words in English and French” highlights key examples of this.

See also: Avoiding confusion between English and French terms.

Commonly confused English words

advise (verb) to give advice “They advised their colleagues to complete the project.”	advice (noun) suggestion about what should be done “The committee chair heeded their advice.”
affect (verb) to have an impact or influence “The new legislation affected most taxpayers.”	effect (verb) to accomplish or cause to happen “The measure effected real change.”
allude to (verb) to mention indirectly “She alluded to similar projects to support her analysis.”	refer to (verb) to mention directly “He referred to last year’s results in the report.”
already (adv.) by this time or earlier “The team already prepared the report.”	all ready (adj. phrase) completely prepared “They are all ready for the conference.”
all together (pron. + adj.) with each other, in a group “They were all together at the conference.”	altogether (adv.) entirely, in total “The director was not altogether pleased with the results.”
alternate (adj.) every other “The team alternates between working on site and remotely.”	alternative (noun or adj.) another option “Remote work is an alternative offered to all staff.”
among (prep.) referring to more than two persons or things “The work will be divided equally among the staff.”	between (prep.) referring to two persons or things “The friendship between the two countries is considerable.”
amount (noun) referring to bulk, mass or aggregate nouns “A large amount of snow fell last night.”	number (noun) referring to nouns that are countable “There are five candidates for the position.”
anyone (pron.) any person at all “Anyone may attend the meeting.”	any one (adj. phrase) unspecified object, idea, place, or person within a group “Any one statistician may represent the directorate.”
appraise (verb) to evaluate “The committee will soon appraise the work of the task force.”	apprise (verb) to inform (but use of this verb should be avoided) “She will apprise inform you of the findings.”
approve (verb) to give official consent “The manager approved the contract.”	approve of (verb) to regard favourably “The staff approved of their new offices.”

balance (noun) what is left after something has been subtracted or used, in a monetary or financial context “After payments had been made, the balance was smaller.”	remainder (noun) what is left after something has been subtracted or used (but should be avoided; prefer rest) “They took the remainder rest of the boxes to the new office.”
biennial (adj.) once every two years “The <i>OECD Pensions Outlook</i> is a biennial report.”	biannual (adj.) twice a year “The biannual conference is held in June and December.”
comparatively (adv.) in comparison to something else “Inflation was 15% in Q3, but comparatively low in Q4.”	relatively (adv.) to some extent, moderately “The meeting was relatively short.”
compare to (verb) used to show similarities (especially between unlike things) “The director compared the team's effort to a marathon.”	compare with (verb) used to analyse differences and similarities (between like things) “Attendance dropped compared with the event in previous years.”
dependent (adj.) determined or conditioned by something else “The project is dependent on the budget being passed.”	dependant (noun) something or someone that is dependent “Several countries offer subsidies for households with dependants.”
farther (adv.) refers to physical distance “The room is farther down the corridor, on the left.”	further (adv.) refers to additional degree, time or quantity “The report needs further revisions before publication.”
forego (verb) to precede “The foregoing section contains three tables.”	forgo (verb) to do without “They decided to forgo tables in the second chapter of the report.”
foreword (noun) the front matter of a publication “The Foreword explained the context of the report.”	forward (adv.) towards the direction that is in front of you “The team is looking forward to the next project phase.”
formally (adverb) in a formal way “The country formally expressed interest in OECD accession.”	formerly (adv.) earlier, in the past “The OECD was formerly known as the OEEC.”
historic (adj.) famous or important in history “The Château de la Muette is a historic monument.”	historical (adj.) of, belonging to or referring to history “The team reviewed historical data to identify trends.”

imply (verb) to state indirectly, to suggest “The speaker implied that the report needed further work.”	infer (verb) to deduce, to draw a conclusion “The author inferred more work was needed.”
inter (prefix) among, between, together “The OECD is an international organisation.”	intra (prefix) within, inside “The patient was given an intravenous drip.”
license (verb) to issue a license, to give permission “Doctors are licensed by a medical board.”	licence (noun) permission, a permit “In most countries, you must be 18 to have a driver’s licence.”
practise (verb) to perform or carry out; to work at so as to become proficient “She practises law in Paris.” “He practised giving the presentation.”	practice (noun) something that is usually or regularly done “The report highlights best practices for policymakers.”
principal (adj. or noun) chief, leading; the head of something “The high school principal addressed the students.”	principle (noun only) rule, guideline or fact “The report provides 10 principles for developing sound policy.”
stationary (adj.) fixed, immobile “The gym’s equipment included stationary bikes.”	stationery (noun) paper, envelopes, writing materials “The stationery has the OECD logo on it.”
spelled (past tense of “to spell”) “She spelled out her name.”	spelt (past participle of “to spell”) “The word is spelt with a ‘z’.”
then (adv.) next, after that “They met with stakeholders, then started drafting the report.”	than (prep. or conj.) used in comparisons “The new edition is shorter than the previous one.”
Assure , ensure and insure (verbs)	Assure (verb), to set the mind at rest, used to refer to people “The teacher assured the students the test would not be difficult.” Ensure (verb), to make sure or certain, used to refer to things or events “The teacher ensured the test was at an appropriate level.” Insure (verb), to indemnify against risk or loss “The OECD premises are insured.”

Autarchy, autarky and autocracy	Autarchy (noun), absolute sovereignty “The ruler established autarchy, holding absolute power over all decisions.” Autarky (noun), economic self-sufficiency “The nation pursued autarky to avoid foreign economic dependence.” Autocracy (noun) absolute government by one person “In an autocracy, citizens have no say in government decisions.”
Continual, continuous , and continued	Continual (adj.), happening frequently “His continual interjections were irritating.” Continuous (adj.), uninterrupted, incessant “We witnessed football's oldest continuous rivalry.” Continued (adj.), lasting, extending “They wished for her continued success.”
Quite, rather and somewhat (adv.)	These words are imprecise and can sound informal. Avoid them.
Respectively (adv.), latter (adj.) and former (adj.)	These words break the flow of the reader's eye movement as the reader must look back in the sentence to see the connection between the words. Avoid them.

Commonly misused words in English

Word	Explanation
Across (prep.)	Can be ambiguous. “The report presented data on unemployment across several countries” – does this mean data within countries, on each of several countries, or on a group of countries? Be specific. “The report compared the unemployment data of several countries.”
Address (verb)	Imprecise. Replace with a more specific word such as “discuss” or “investigate”.
All right (adj., adv.)	Always two words. “Alright” is incorrect.
And/or (n/a)	Do not use. Rephrase to “A or B, or both”. “You may present your passport or identity card, or both.”
Annex (noun)	Always use. Do not use “appendix”.
Comprise (verb)	To consist or be made of all the parts of that make up a whole. “The final report comprises six chapters and two annexes.” Not a synonym for “contain” or “include”. Do not use “is comprised of”; this is incorrect.
Concerted (adj.)	By agreement, in unison. Must be used to refer to one or more countries, institutions or individuals; one alone cannot make a concerted effort.
Consensus (noun)	Means “shared opinion”, not “majority view”.

Word	Explanation
Constitute (verb)	The parts that make up a whole. “The House of Commons and the House of Lords constitute the Parliament of the United Kingdom.” Not to be confused with “contain”: “This report contains the group’s findings, the result of three years of work” (correct) but “This report constitutes three years of work” (incorrect).
Impact (noun)	Do not use as a verb: “The policy had a direct impact on pollution” (correct) but “The policy impacted pollution” (incorrect).
Implement (verb)	Means “carry out”, “execute”, “accomplish”. Much overused, employ synonyms when possible.
In regard to (prep.)	“In regard to” is the proper expression; use “regard” (with no “s”) rather than “regards”.
Include (verb)	Means “part of a whole”, does not mean “comprise”. “The countries supporting this policy include Denmark, Norway and Sweden.” In this example, using “include” means that at least one other country supports the policy. Do not use the phrase “including but not limited to”; it is redundant.
Literally (adv.)	Something happened exactly as described. “They literally drove five hours to attend the event.” Only use in this sense. Does not mean “in effect” or “virtually”. “He literally exploded” would mean there were bits of him all over the walls, floor and ceiling. Do not use metaphorically.
Loan (noun)	Means “an amount of borrowed money”. “The firm has repaid the loan.” Do not use as a verb, use “lend”. “The bank lends money at a fixed interest rate.”
Presently (adv.)	Do not use , to avoid confusion between the difference in its meaning between British English (“soon”) and American English (“now”).
Regardless (adv.)	Means “despite” or “not affected by”. “Regardless of their department, all staff are encouraged to contribute ideas.” Do not use “irregardless”; it is a double negative and is not equivalent to “regardless”.
Regime (noun)	Means “government or system of government”, “a particular way of doing something”. If used refer to the government of a country, usually implies dictatorship and is considered pejorative. Do not use in this context.
Regular (adj.)	Means “at regular intervals”. “Halley’s comet regularly approaches the Earth, appearing in the skies every 76 years.” Does not mean “frequent”.
Scheme (noun)	Means “plan” or “project”. Do not use as it carries a negative connotation of “sneaky” or “devious” in American English. Use instead a word that is neutral in both British and American English (“programme”, “project”, “plan” or “initiative”).
Slated (adj.)	Do not use , to avoid confusion between the difference in its meaning between British English (“severely criticised”) and in American English (“scheduled”).
State (noun)	Meanings include “a country”, “level of government” or “government”. Be careful to clarify your meaning, as “state” can be confusing in discussions involving countries with federal governments, such as the United States and Germany.
Table (verb)	Do not use , to avoid confusion between the difference in its meaning between British English (“to present something”) and in American English (“to take off the agenda”).

Commonly confused spellings of similar words in English and French

English	French
abbreviation	<i>abréviation</i>
address	<i>adresse</i>
apartment	<i>appartement</i>
character	<i>caractère</i>
competitiveness	<i>compétitivité</i>
connection	<i>connexion</i>
contract	<i>contrat</i>
correspondence	<i>correspondance</i>
defence	<i>défense</i>
environment	<i>environnement</i>
example	<i>exemple</i>
existent	<i>existant</i>
government	<i>gouvernement</i>
independence, independent	<i>indépendance, indépendant</i>
medicine	<i>médecine</i>
messenger	<i>messenger</i>
negligible	<i>négligeable</i>
negotiation	<i>négociation</i>
offence	<i>offense</i>
parallel	<i>parallèle</i>
recommendation	<i>recommandation</i>
reflection	<i>réflexion</i>
responsible	<i>responsable</i>
tariff	<i>tarif</i>
traffic	<i>trafic</i>
weekend	<i>week-end</i>

Plurals

- Most nouns can be turned into plural nouns by adding “-s”, “-es” or another suffix.
- Some nouns, often called “**mass nouns**”, remain in the singular even when expressing plurality, usually for abstract concepts or uncountable objects (“**advice**”, “**information**”, “**knowledge**” or “**snow**”).
- Some Latin and ancient Greek terms are used in modern English. Their singular and plural forms are listed in the table “Singular and plural forms of Latin or Greek terms commonly used in English”. Be aware that while English uses the Latin or Greek form for the plural (“**a forum**”, **but** “**several fora**”), French adds an “s” to the singular form (“**un forum**”, **but** “**des forums**”).

Do

- ✓ Use the correct ending when making a noun plural. Consult the *Concise Oxford English Dictionary* if you are unsure of which form to use.
- ✓ Use a singular verb form if a mass noun is the subject of the sentence.
The team always brings sandwiches on their picnics.
The information was shared with the committee.

Singular and plural forms of Latin or Greek terms commonly used in English

Singular	Plural	Singular	Plural
addendum	addenda	forum	forums or fora
agenda	agendas	index	indexes (of books)
appendix	appendices	index	indices (indicators, index numbers)
colloquium	colloquia	matrix	matrices
consortium	consortia	medium	media
corrigendum	corrigenda	memorandum	memoranda
criterion	criteria	nucleus	nuclei
curriculum	curricula	phenomenon	phenomena
data (always plural)	data	premium	premiums
equilibrium	equilibria	referendum	referendums
erratum	errata	syllabus	Syllabuses
formula	formulas (general)	symposium	symposia
formula	formulae (scientific, mathematics)	ultimatum	ultimatums

14 Translation and terms in other languages

Correctly translating words and expressions from other languages is essential for high-quality content and to avoid offense. The OECD offers a professional translation service and translation tools to help ensure OECD writing is accurate and clear.

AGORA translation portal

- AGORA offers verified translations and definitions for key terms used in OECD outputs. It is available at <https://portal.oecd.org/Pages/HowTos/EXD-CSI/-How-to-check-terminology.aspx>.

Do

- ✓ Use AGORA to:
 - Check the exact meaning of a term or expression.
 - Find out exactly how to describe a concept or how to translate it.
 - Suggest a translation or terms for inclusion.

Word count coefficients for translation

- The word count coefficient indicates the difference between the word count of the original text and that of the translation. See the table below.

Do

- ✓ Keep this coefficient in mind when drafting content, particularly for web and social media, as a term that fits into your layout in one language may not in another.

Word count coefficients from English to other languages

Target language	Word coefficient	Target language	Word coefficient
French	+30%	Korean	-10%
German	+15%	Russian	+15%
Italian	+20%	Spanish	+25%
Japanese	-10%		

Using titles, terms and expressions from other languages

- Not all readers will be familiar with titles, terms or expressions from other languages; prioritise clarity. Avoid foreign words and expressions when commonly understood alternatives exist in English.

See also: Choosing the right words.

Do

- ✓ Put all titles, terms or expressions from other languages into italics, except for common abbreviations and proper names (*Deutsche Bundesbank*).
- ✓ Provide an English translation for titles and terms from other languages and put the translation in parentheses afterwards **or** use the English translation and put the original title or term in parentheses after it. Be consistent in which style you use.

Public authorities worked together to create *Efterlevandeguiden* (Survivor's Guide), a website that gathers essential information and walks survivors through the various necessary steps.

In 2018, Mexico's Ministry of Public Administration (*Secretaría de la Función Pública*) established a multi-stakeholder group for the reform of CompraNet, its e-procurement system.

See also: Abbreviations, acronyms and signs.

Don't

- ✗ Use terms from Latin when a simple English equivalent is available. See table below. Note that alternatives depend on context.

Latin terms to avoid

Avoid	Use	Avoid	Use
<i>a contrario</i>	on the contrary	<i>grosso modo</i>	roughly, approximately
<i>a fortiori</i>	even more so, all the more	<i>in extenso</i>	in full
<i>a minima</i>	at minimum	<i>in extremis</i>	as a last resort, at the last moment
<i>a posteriori</i>	based on experience	<i>in situ</i>	in its original situation
<i>a priori</i>	logically, theoretically, assuming	<i>inter alia</i>	among other things
<i>ad valorem</i>	according to the value	<i>ipso facto</i>	by the mere fact
<i>ceteris paribus</i>	other things being equal	<i>modus operandi</i>	way of working, method
<i>de minimis</i>	small amounts	<i>sine die</i>	with no fixed date
<i>ex nihilo</i>	from nothing, without precedent	<i>stricto sensu</i>	strict sense
<i>ex officio</i>	by virtue of the office held	<i>ultra vires</i>	beyond one's authority

Avoiding confusion between English and French terms

- “False friends”, semantic calques and even simply multiple ways to translate one term can lead to difficulties in choosing the right word or concept in English and French.
- The tables below will be regularly updated and available on the “OECD Communications Guidance Portal”: <https://com-apps.oecd.org/com-guidance-portal/en>.
- The OECD Translation Service provides professional translations and revisions. Learn more about their work: https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/exd-csi/kc/Wiki/Translation%20Division_fr.aspx.

Concepts often used at the OECD

English	French
accountability	<i>responsabilité, transparence</i>
blockchains	<i>chaînes de blocs</i>
carbon pricing	<i>tarification carbone</i>
chemical safety	<i>sécurité des produits chimiques</i>
climate finance	<i>financement climatique</i>
corporate governance	<i>gouverance d'entreprise (appelé « gouvernement d'entreprise » jusqu'en 2015)</i>
donor countries	<i>pays donateurs, pays donneurs (développement)</i>
due diligence	<i>devoir de diligence, diligence raisonnable, obligation de vigilance</i>
entrepreneurship	<i>entrepreneuriat</i>
Global South	<i>les pays du Sud</i>
green transition	<i>transition écologique</i>
inclusive growth	<i>croissance inclusive</i>
inclusiveness	<i>inclusivité</i>
minerals	<i>minéraux, ressources minérales</i>
net-zero emissions	<i>zéro émission nette, neutralité (carbone, GES)</i>
official development assistance (ODA)	<i>aide publique au développement (APD)</i>
ore	<i>minerais</i>
to provide (for a law, etc.)	<i>énoncer, disposer, prévoir</i>
resilience	<i>résilience</i>
responsible business conduct (RBC)	<i>conduite responsable des entreprises (CRE)</i>
supply chains	<i>chaînes d'approvisionnement</i>
sustainability	<i>durabilité, soutenabilité, viabilité, pérennité</i>
Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)	<i>Objectifs de développement durable (ODD)</i>
value chains	<i>chaînes de valeur</i>

“False friends” (or *faux amis*)

- “False friends” are words that look or sound similar in French and English, but have significantly different meanings, as shown in the table below.

English word	French translation	Not to be confused with	Which means
to complete	<i>achever</i>	to achieve	<i>réaliser</i>
bit, small piece	<i>bribe</i>	bribe	<i>pot-de-vin</i>
to change, to alter	<i>changer</i>	change	<i>monnaie</i>
cheque	<i>chèque</i>	check	<i>contrôle</i>
secret	<i>confidence</i>	confidence	<i>confiance</i>
to ask	<i>demander</i>	to demand	<i>exiger</i>

Incorrect semantic calques

- A semantic calque occurs when an English word, for example, is used with the meaning of a French word that has a similar form.

English word	French translation	Not to be confused with	Which means
according to	<i>conformément à, selon, etc.</i>	<i>en accord avec</i>	in agreement with
actually	<i>en réalité, en fait</i>	<i>actuellement</i>	currently
to address (an issue)	<i>aborder, traiter une question</i>	<i>adresser (une lettre)</i> <i>adresser (des reproches)</i>	to address (a letter) to address (reproaches)
agenda	<i>ordre du jour</i>	<i>agenda</i>	diary, notebook
alternatively	<i>à l'inverse, par contre, en revanche</i>	<i>alternativement</i>	alternately
to apply for	<i>postuler, demander</i>	<i>appliquer (une mesure)</i>	to apply (a measure) to implement
assertive (s.o.)	<i>assuré, faisant preuve d'assurance</i>	<i>une phrase assertive</i>	an assertive sentence
to assume	<i>supposer, prendre pour hypothèse, partir du principe que</i>	<i>assumer la responsabilité</i>	to take responsibility
basic	<i>fondamental (les libertés fondamentales)</i> <i>essentiel (les besoins essentiels)</i>	<i>(roche) basique</i>	basic (rock)
comprehensive	<i>complet, détaillé, exhaustif</i>	<i>compréhensif</i>	understanding

English word	French translation	Not to be confused with	Which means
consistent	<i>cohérent, systématique, homogène</i>	(repas) consistant	substantial (meal)
decade	<i>décennie</i>	décade	ten days
definitely	<i>certainement, assurément tout à fait</i>	définitivement	definitively
to deliver	<i>livrer (un colis), distribuer (les journaux) formuler (une opinion) libérer (qqn) exécuter (un projet)</i>	délivrer (un passeport) délivrer (des otages)	to issue (a passport) to rescue (hostages)
discontinued	<i>abandonné arrêté</i>	discontinu	discontinuous
to finalise	<i>achever (des travaux) établir la version définitive (d'un rapport) mener (un projet) à terme parachever</i>	finaliser	to assign a goal
fiscal	<i>budgétaire</i>	fiscal	tax
irreconcilable (opinions)	<i>inconciliables</i>	irréconciliables (des adversaires...)	
to minimise (= to reduce to the smallest possible amount or degree)	<i>limiter au minimum réduire le plus possible</i>	minimiser	to minimise (= to represent or estimate at less than the true value or importance)
to mitigate	<i>atténuer (les risques) réduire (les émissions)</i>	mitiger (une assertion)	
registration (to attend a meeting)	<i>inscription (à une réunion)</i>	enregistrement (d'une candidature) enregistrement des bagages	(candidate) registration (luggage) check-in
versatile	<i>polyvalent</i>	versatile	volatile

Resources

Dictionaries

- Angus Stevenson, A. and M. Waite (2011), *The Concise Oxford Dictionary*, Oxford University Press, Oxford.
- “YourDictionary.com” is a collection of online dictionaries, one of the oldest and best sites for language links in English and a host of other languages: <https://www.yourdictionary.com/>.

Style guides and grammar resources

- Fowler, H.W. and F.G. Fowler (1924), *The King’s English*, Oxford at the Clarendon Press, London. (Later editions are known as *Fowler’s Dictionary of Modern English Usage*; the most recent was published in 2015.) Of its time, but useful for grammar questions. Early editions are in the public domain and available online: <https://www.gutenberg.org/cache/epub/75439/pg75439-images.html>.
- Lane, G. (2023), *Writing with Style: The Economist Guide*, The Economist, London.
- Oxford University Press (2016), *New Oxford Style Manual, Third Edition*, Oxford University Press, Oxford.
- Strunk, W. (1918), *The Elements of Style*, Harcourt, Brace and Co., New York. The one and only “Strunk & White”, a classic guide to the “plain English style”. Earlier editions are in the public domain and available online: <https://www.gutenberg.org/cache/epub/37134/pg37134-images.html>.

Plain language, clear writing

- The “Plain English Campaign” helps organisations to ensure their public information is as simple and understandable as possible: <https://www.plainenglish.co.uk/free-guides>.
- The Plain Language Action and Information Network (PLAIN) supports clear communication in government writing: <https://www.plainlanguage.gov/guidelines/>.

- Orwell, G. (1946), “Politics and the English Language”, *Horizon* 13, London, pp. 252-265. Contains the six most famous rules for clear writing in English. Available at <https://www.orwellfoundation.com/the-orwell-foundation/orwell/essays-and-other-works/politics-and-the-english-language/>.
- OECD editorial standards and writing guidelines are available for OECD staff on the “OECD Communications Guidance Portal” (<https://com-apps.oecd.org/com-guidance-portal/en>).
- “Clear writing tips” provided by the OECD Translation Service help staff to produce clear and easily comprehensible content and navigate the hidden subtleties of writing in English at the OECD. They are available for OECD staff on the “Translation Portal” ([https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/exd-csi/kc/Wiki/Translation Division en.aspx](https://portal.oecd.org/eshare/exd-csi/kc/Wiki/Translation%20Division_en.aspx)).

Data visualisation

Nussbaumer Knaflic, C. (2015), *Storytelling with Data: A Data Visualization Guide for Business Professionals*, Wiley, Hoboken.

OECD Style Guide (Fourth Edition)

This fourth edition of the *OECD Style Guide* outlines the rules and conventions to be used in OECD writing. It is designed to assist authors and editors in producing high-quality, consistent content that resonates with diverse audiences across various dissemination channels.



PRINT ISBN 978-92-64-57671-1
PDF ISBN 978-92-64-34105-0

